MODULE 10 · AMBITIOUS ENTREPRENEURSHIP

Product Management & Growth

What do you build next, and what do you refuse to build?

COURSE PATH



COURSE MATERIAL · SCAN NOW

All slides live on GitHub

The newest version, free, no account needed

github.com/BaNburger/
AmbitiousEntrepreneurship

1. **Open the link**
   github.com/BaNburger/AmbitiousEntrepreneurship
2. **Go to modules**
   then 10-product-management
3. **Click the lecture PDF**
   M10_Lecture_Product-Management.pdf, download top right

WHERE WE ARE · THE COURSE

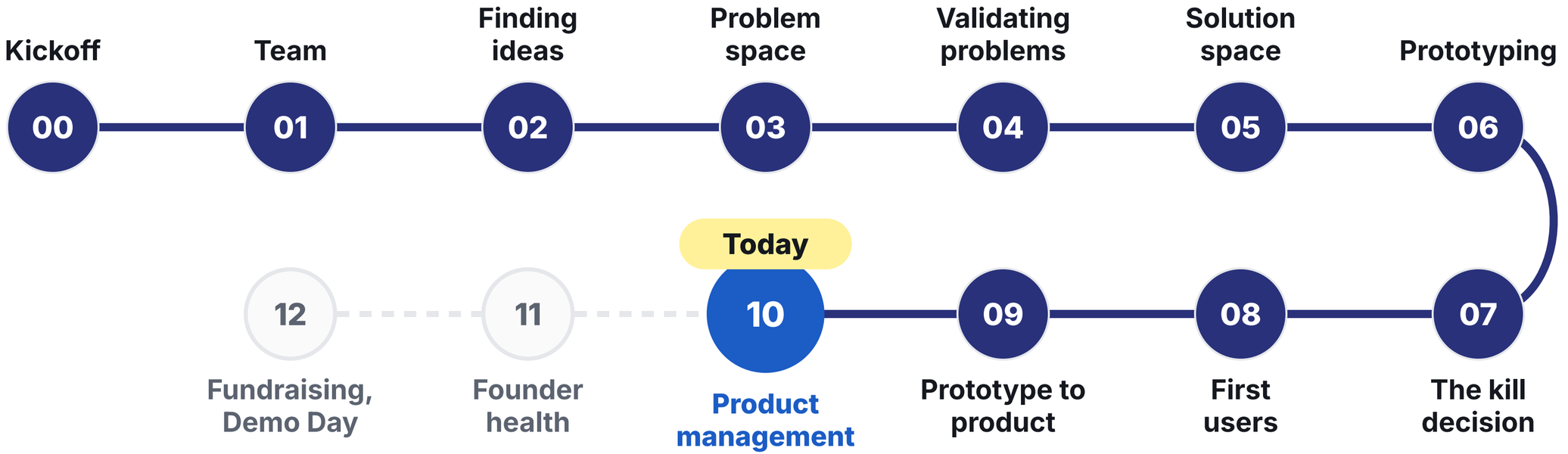
From paying users to users who stay

Thirteen sessions from first idea to first revenue. What teams have by now:

First paying users
First users (M08)

Payments inside the product
Prototype to product (M09)

One offer sold more than once
Prototype to product (M09)



FOR A MODULE ON ITS OWN

Three words, and a made-up tool that nudges recruiters

Outcome
What a customer pays for. Your product writes a row each time it happens.

The core
The part of your product that delivers the outcome.

Kill line
A result you count, a date, and what you do if you cross it, written down before the data comes in.



Our running example, made up. A tool that nudges recruiters when a finalist goes quiet. Six agencies pay €99 a seat. Founders Ana, Jonas and Mia. Customer Lena.

ILLUSTRATIVE Definitions from frameworks 02 and 06. The recruiter tool is the course's made-up venture. Photo: Tumisu on Pixabay.

CHECK-IN · SHOW OF HANDS

What did the market pay you, and who came back?

Customers who used it again or paid again

?	0	1	2+
we can't tell	nobody came back	customer came back	customers came back

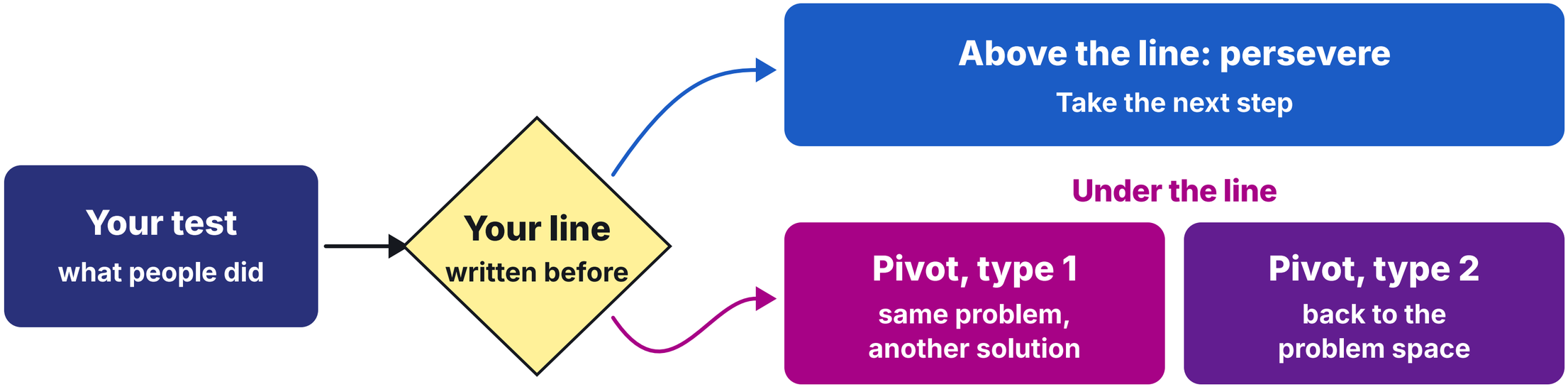
2:00

How much since last time? What did they ask for that you haven't built?

PIVOT OR PERSEVERE

Under your line? That is a decision, not a failure

Your last test: did people pay at your price, inside the product?



Both are progress. The only miss: no line, so no decision

FRAMEWORK Pivot or persevere after Ries, E. (2011), The Lean Startup. Pivot types as in the course Glossary.

ACCOUNTABILITY

Report what you did, not what you planned



User interactions?

What did you learn?



New revenue?

Why did they pay?



Shipped?

Why does it matter?

🦄 **Report target vs. actual in small groups**

CHAPTER 1 OF 9

Previously on Ambitious Entrepreneurship

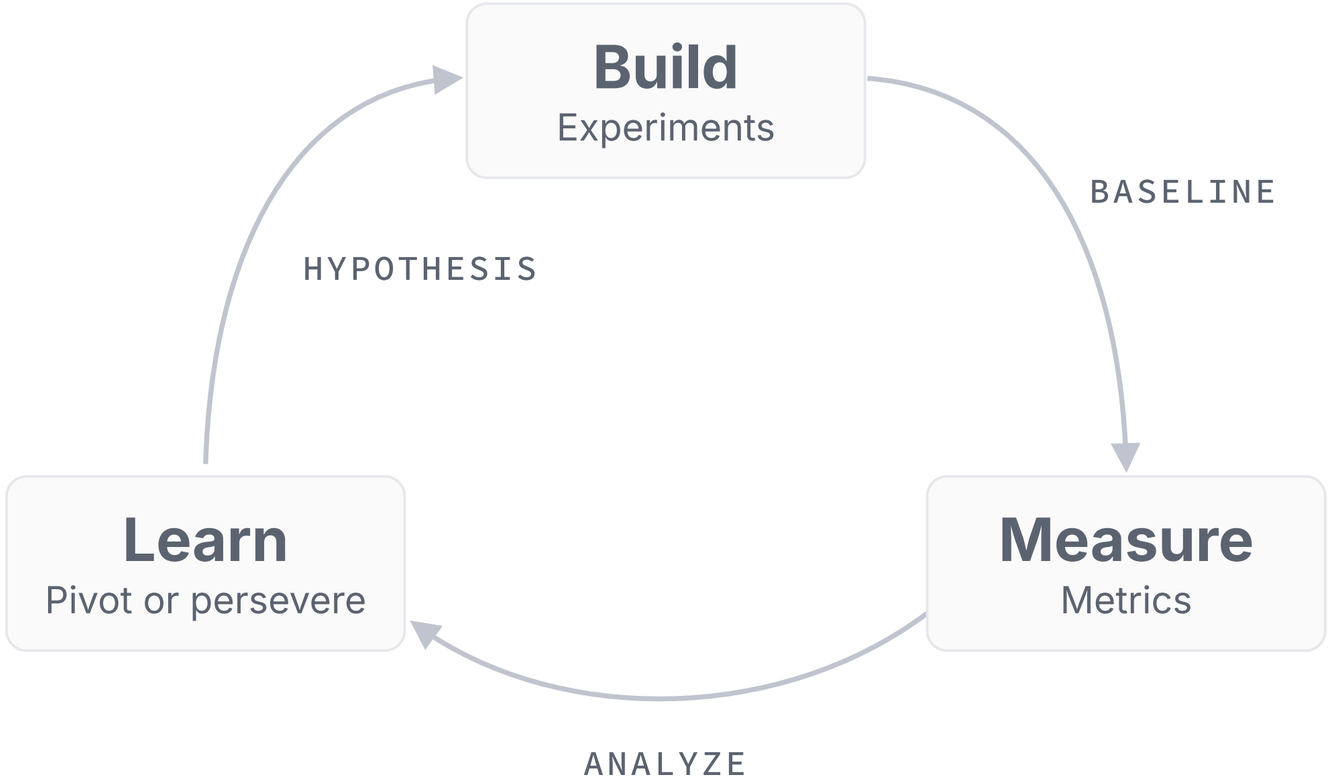
Four pictures from earlier sessions that today builds on.

01 **Previously on Ambitious Entrepreneurship**
02 Your presentations
03 **Count it: who stays and who leaves**
04 **Focus it: one number and its drivers**
05 **Choose it: build less, refuse more**
06 **Run it: the week, build or grow**
07 Wrap-up and check-out
08 Workshop: Feature Graveyard
09 Case discussion

PREVIOUSLY · KICKOFF (M00)

Every feature is a bet you test in loops

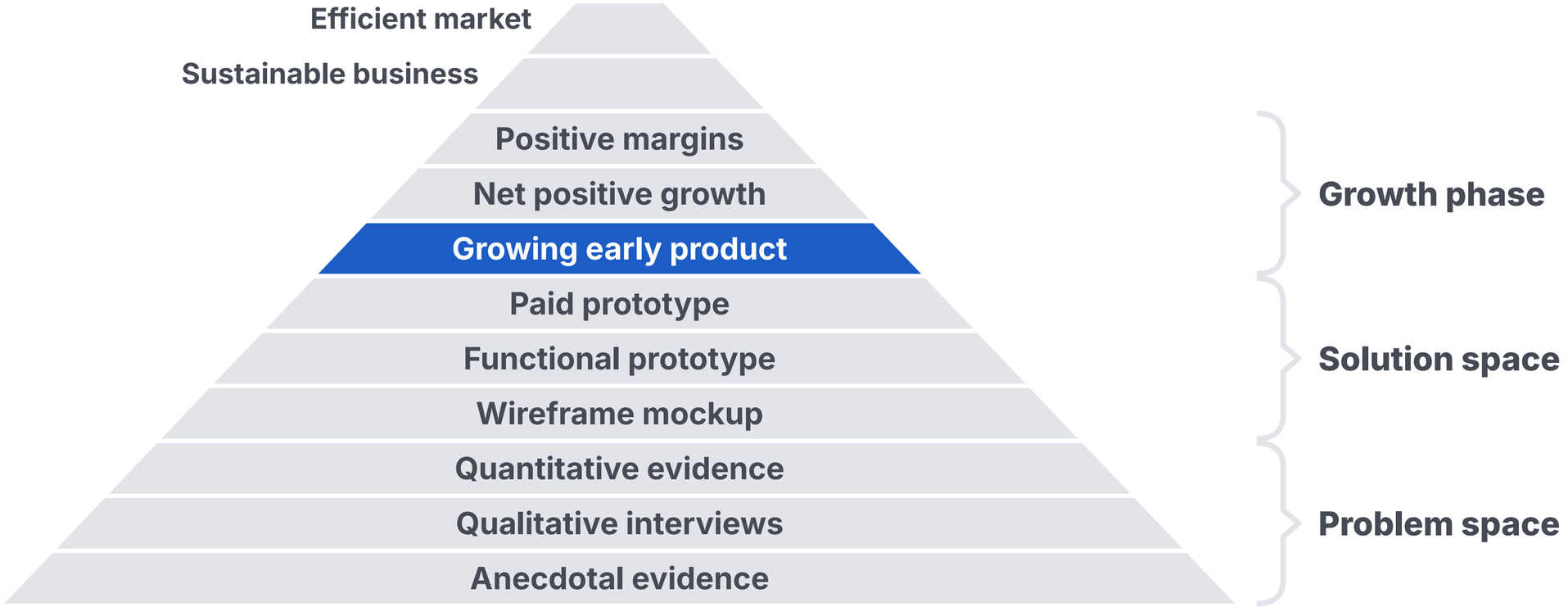
Build the smallest test, measure what people do, decide



FRAMEWORK Ries, E. (2011). The Lean Startup. Crown Business. Course graphic of Kickoff (M00).

PREVIOUSLY · PROTOTYPE TO PRODUCT (M09)

They paid. Now, do they stay?



PREVIOUSLY · FIRST USERS (M08)

The last box leaks. Count who leaves

IMPRESSIONS
- Always be posting
- Improve your targeting
- Improve your relevance

Tool
Posting & outreach

CLICKS
- Farm your friends & family
- Guide through keynotes & presentations

Tool
Keep the flywheel going

SIGN-UPS
- Demos, interviews, ...
- Personal interaction

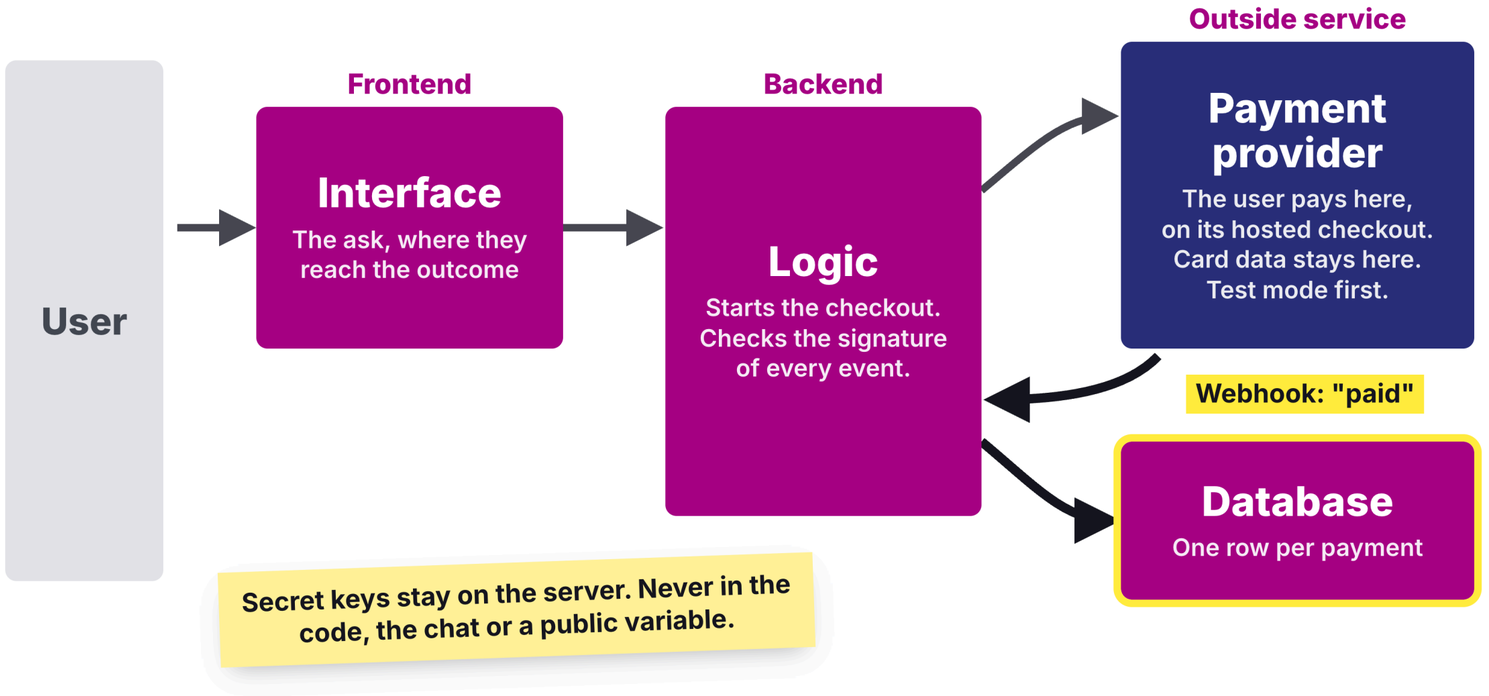
Tool
Interviewing techniques

CUSTOMERS
- Show attention
- Manage your funnel
- Be their concierge

Tool
Managing your funnel

PREVIOUSLY · PROTOTYPE TO PRODUCT (M09)

Every payment wrote a row. Those rows know who stays



CHAPTER 2 OF 9

Your presentations

Your paying customers, who came back and what they asked for, three minutes per team.

01 ~~Previously on Ambitious Entrepreneurship~~

02 **Your presentations**

03 **Count it: who stays and who leaves**

04 **Focus it: one number and its drivers**

05 **Choose it: build less, refuse more**

06 **Run it: the week, build or grow**

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YOUR PRESENTATIONS · MAKE IT CREDIBLE

Show us where you're at in 3 minutes or less!

3:00

Facts

Statistics or research

The offer, its unit, the tested price, where the ask sits in the product

12 Numbers

Usage or surveys

Revenue from outside the social graph against the bar (€500 floor, €1,000 full), repeat customers

Quotes

Interviews

Two price objections word for word, with roles

Images

Screenshots or users

Payment dashboard, cropped, no customer data

What did you do? **What did you learn?** **How can we help?**

LET'S JUMP IN!

The skills that got you your first €1,000 are not the skills that get you to

€10K

Hustle brought you here.
Systems take you further.

Count it: who stays and who leaves

Count who came back from your product's records, because leavers cap your growth.

01 ~~Previously on Ambitious Entrepreneurship~~

02 ~~Your presentations~~

03 **Count it: who stays and who leaves**

04 **Focus it: one number and its drivers**

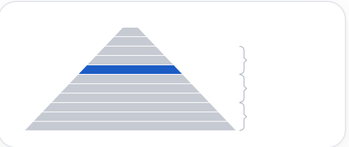
05 **Choose it: build less, refuse more**

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INPUT 1 OF 4 · COUNT IT · THREE QUESTIONS

Are they staying?

1

Why does churn matter so much?

2

How do you know who stayed?

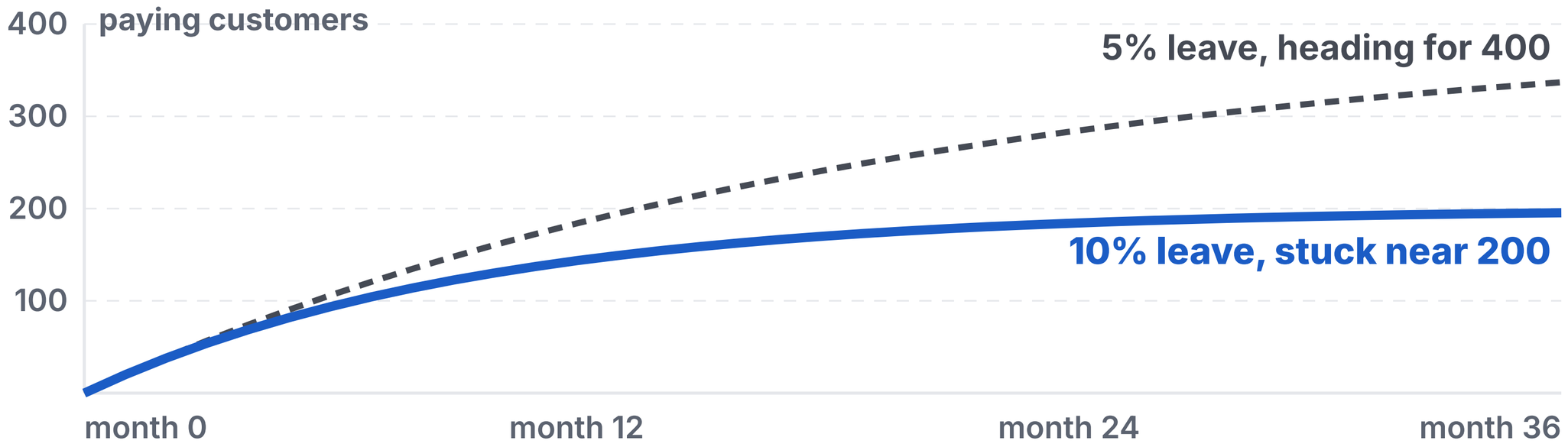
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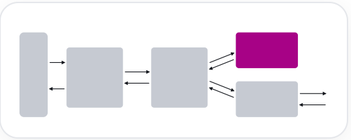
Who do you build for?

CHURN

Churn is your mathematical limit to growth

20 new customers a month, 10% leave. You stop near 200





RETENTION

Count who came back from what your product records

Your database and payment rows, never your inbox

Database · table editor

TABLES

customers

events

payments

Filter `event = outcome_used`

event	customer	date
outcome_used	agency 4	14 Oct
outcome_used	agency 5	12 Oct
…		
outcome_used	agency 2	2 Oct then none

Came back means the outcome again, or a second payment. A kind email is not a row.

ILLUSTRATIVE "Every application ever", the database. Screen prototyped for this deck. Event rows made up, the recruiter tool from First users (M08) and Prototype to product (M09).



COHORTS

Read it per cohort, in counts

Under 20 people, write 4 of 5, never 80%. You never type it, your agent fills it

	A	B	C	D	E
1	**Cohort**	**Customer**	**Paid on**	**Back on (used or paid, date)**	**Lost, reason in their words**
2	Wk 28 Sep	Agency 1 · Lena	30 Sep	**9 Oct, nudge**	
3		Agency 2	1 Oct		"We only hire in spring"
4		Agency 3	2 Oct	**10 Oct, nudge**	
5	Wk 5 Oct	Agency 4	7 Oct	**14 Oct, nudge**	
6		Agency 5	8 Oct	**12 Oct, nudge**	
7	Wk 12 Oct	Agency 6	15 Oct	too new	

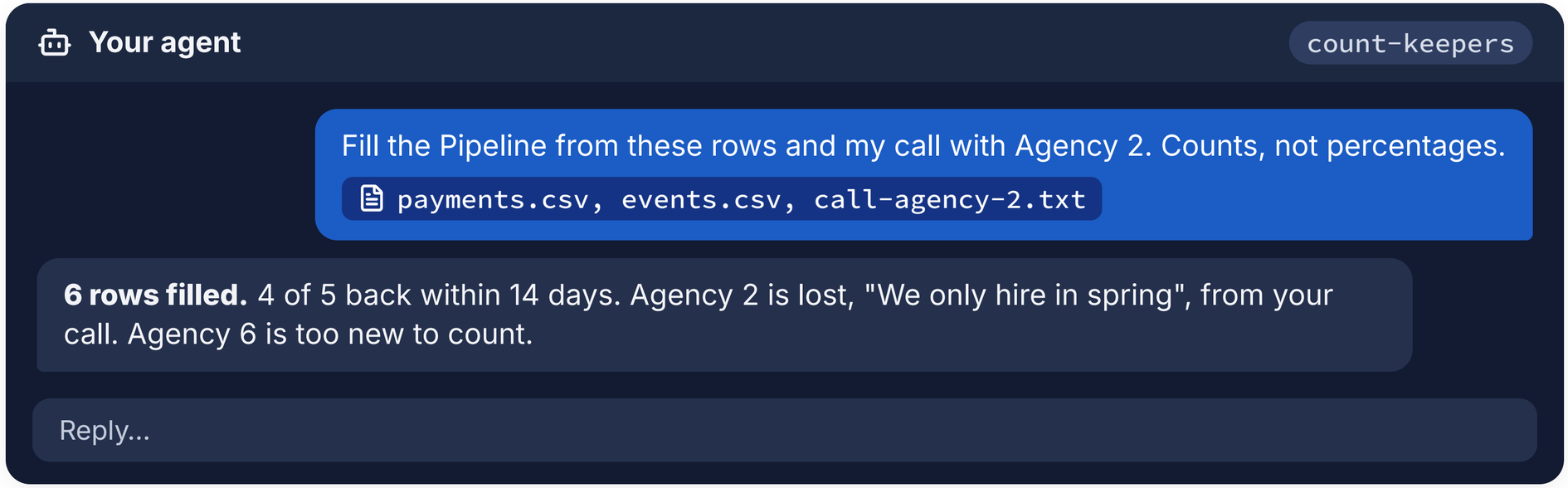
Student Toolkit · Pipeline · read on 20 Oct



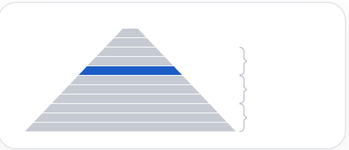
ILLUSTRATIVE Pipeline rows and chat made up, the recruiter tool. Columns from the Student Toolkit Pipeline. "Track cohorts, not aggregates" (Bastian).

WITH YOUR AGENT · NOTHING BY HAND

Read it per cohort, in counts



ILLUSTRATIVE Pipeline rows and chat made up, the recruiter tool. Columns from the Student Toolkit Pipeline. "Track cohorts, not aggregates" (Bastian).



THE SEAN ELLIS QUESTION

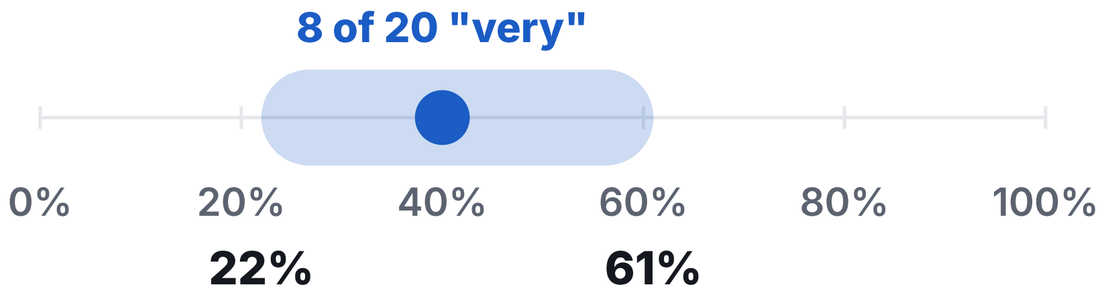
Ask who would miss you. Read it as a compass

At 20 answers, 40% could be anywhere from about 22% to 61%

"How would you feel if you could no longer use [product]?"

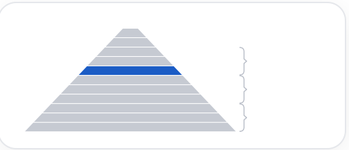
- ● Very disappointed
- ○ Somewhat disappointed
- ○ Not disappointed

Only to people who used the core at least twice in the last two weeks



Share who answer "very disappointed", with its 95% range

FRAMEWORK Ellis (2009), the question and his 40% rule of thumb, "a bit arbitrary". 95% interval for 8 of 20 (Wilson), the course's calculation.



COMPASS AND VERDICT

What they say points. What they do decides

NPS and the Ellis question both ask about the future



SAY · OPINION

Points the way

- "Very disappointed" share
- Net Promoter Score
- "We love it!"

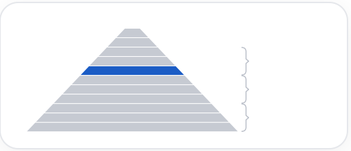


DO · BEHAVIOUR

Decides

- Used the outcome again
- Paid a second time
- Renewed, added a seat

RESEARCH Keiningham et al. (2007), Journal of Marketing, 21 firms and more than 15,500 interviews, fail to replicate NPS as the best predictor of growth.



IDEAL CUSTOMER

Build for the ones who would miss you most

HIGH VALUE

Ideal customer
Most of your effort

Future target
Build toward them later

EASY — HARD

Time waster
Easy to win, hard to grow

Avoid
Walk away

LOW VALUE

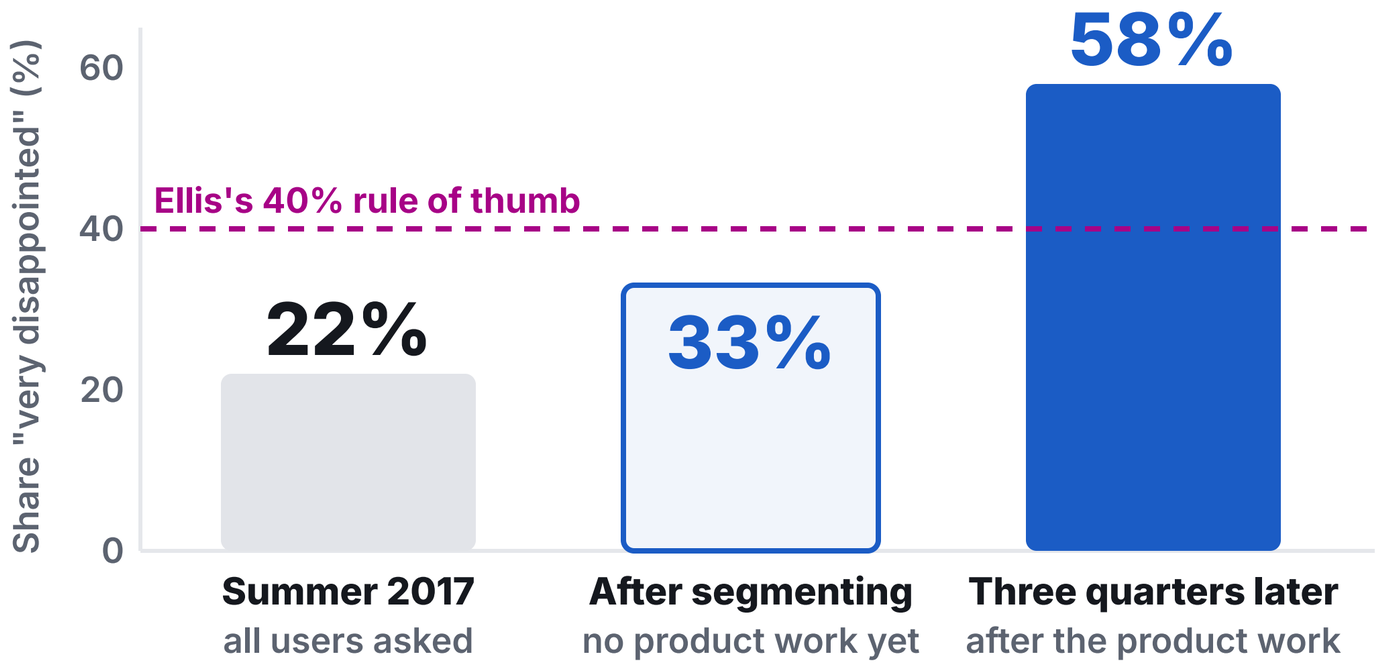
Your ideal customers said "very disappointed" **and** came back. Their words for the main benefit are your positioning.

Customer value matrix. Segmenting by the "very disappointed", Vohra (2018), First Round Review, as framework 06 describes it.

IDEAL CUSTOMER · VOHRA'S OWN EXAMPLE

Superhuman built for its fans and went from 22% to 58%

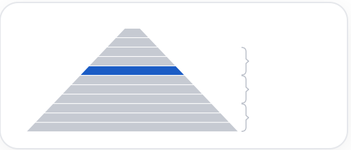
The first jump came from who he counted, the second from the product





Half the roadmap for what fans love, half for what holds the others back

FRAMEWORK Vohra (2018), First Round Review. The company's own figures, 100 to 200 users to poll at the start. Photo: StartupStockPhotos on Pixabay.



NOW YOU · ALONE OR IN PAIRS · 3 MINUTES

Now you: count your keepers



List your paying customers by name

Mark who used the outcome again since paying

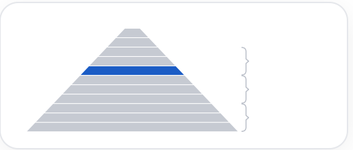
Write the count, not a percentage

3:00

OUTPUT

4 of 6, with names

Photo: Campaign_Creators on Pixabay.



INPUT 1 OF 4 · COUNT IT · THE ANSWERS

Count it: who came back, from your own records

1

Why does churn matter so much?

It caps your growth. 20 new a month with 10% leaving stops near 200

2

How do you know who stayed?

Count who came back in your product's records, per cohort, in counts

3

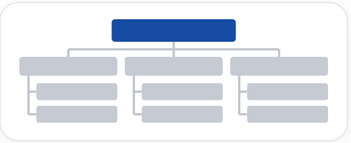
Who do you build for?

Those who would miss you most. What they say points, what they do decides

Focus it: one number and its drivers

Pick one number for the value customers get, then give each driver an owner.

01 ~~Previously on Ambitious Entrepreneurship~~
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INPUT 2 OF 4 · FOCUS IT · THREE QUESTIONS

Which number tells you it works?

1

What is your North Star?

2

How do you move it?

3

Where do you track it?

NORTH STAR

Your North Star counts what customers get, not what you get

Revenue follows from it. It is not the top of the tree

NOT A NORTH STAR

~~Revenue~~

~~Sign-ups~~

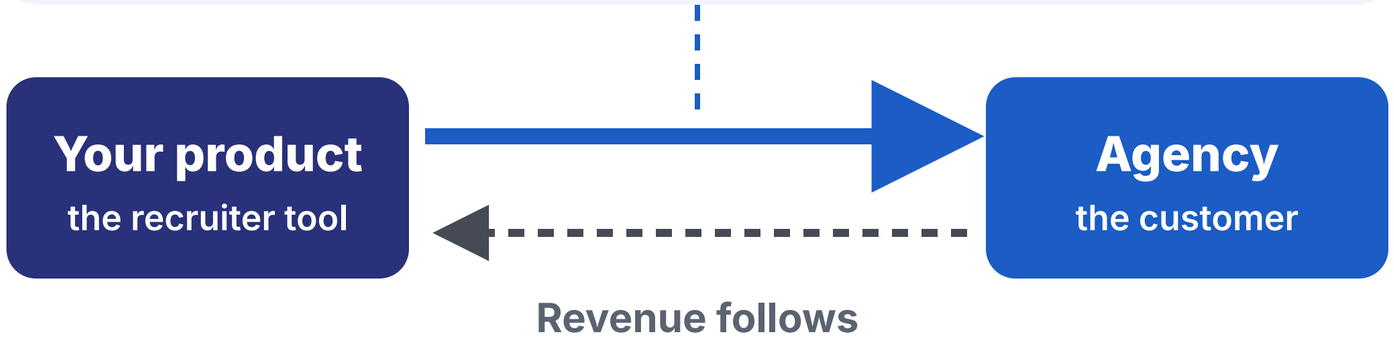
~~Followers~~

~~Page views~~

★ A North Star

Finalists nudged who replied, per week

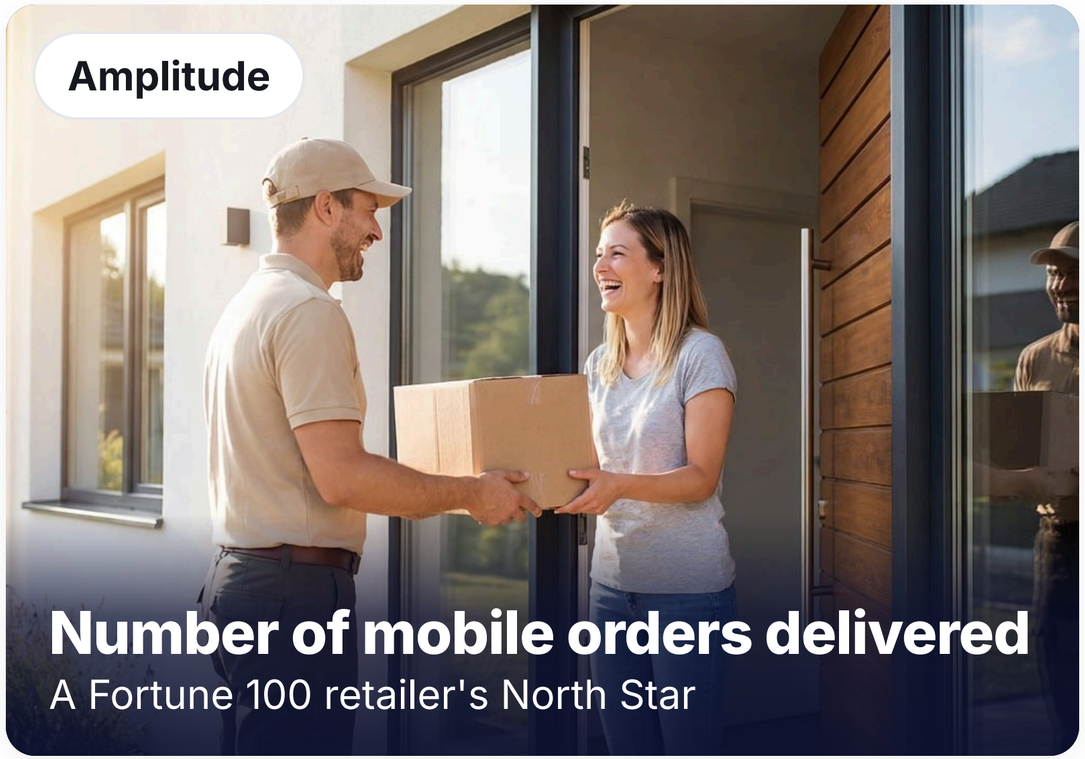
Counts the value an agency pays for, a quiet candidate who answers again



NORTH STAR · AMPLITUDE'S OWN EXAMPLE

A retailer counts mobile orders delivered

Not just ordered. Delivered, with nothing going wrong



Ordered in the app
The team's strategy focus

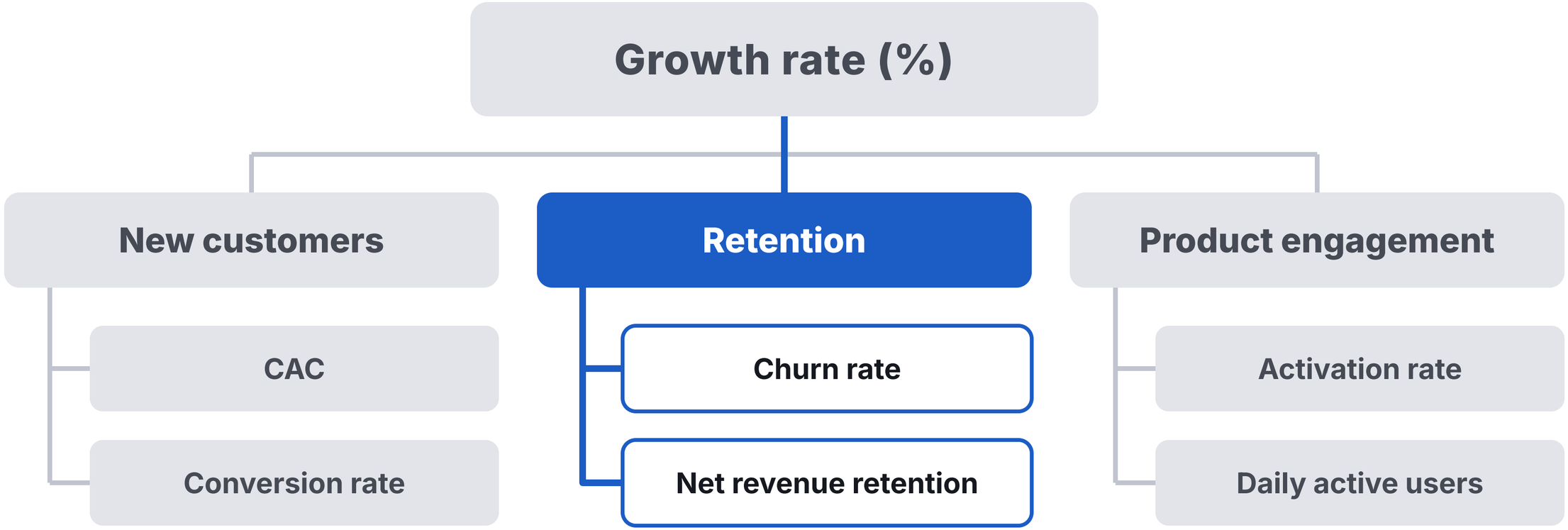
Delivered
No payment issues, no logistics complaints, no returns. The value the customer gets

The recruiter tool has the same shape. Finalists nudged **who replied**

FRAMEWORK Sholtz (2024), Every Product Needs a North Star Metric, Amplitude blog. Photo: u_c48rf6ybx8 on Pixabay.

CORNERSTONE · KPI TREE, FROM TEAM (M01)

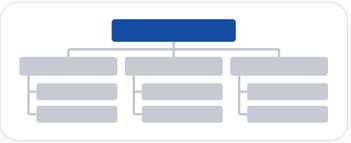
Growth splits into new customers, retention and engagement



KPI TREE

Put your North Star on top, an owner on each driver

Your North Star takes growth's place on top



FOCUS IT · TIP

Count active by the outcome, not by minutes

FROM

"Active user = at least 5 minutes on your site in the last month."

TO

"Active = reached the outcome in the last 7 days."

> Minutes measure attention. The outcome measures value, and it is a row your product already writes.

your database · saved query

TABLES

customers

events

payments

SAVED QUERIES

active_agencies

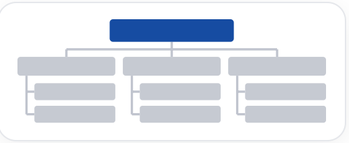
Active agencies ▶ Run

event = outcome_used | a nudge sent | last 7 days | per customer

customer	nudges sent, last 7 days	minutes on site, last 30 days	active
agency 1	11	212	yes
agency 3	8	148	yes
agency 4	10	176	yes
agency 5	9	131	yes
agency 6	7	58	yes
agency 2	0	34	no, last on 2 Oct

Active: 5 of 6 ~~By minutes: 6 of 6~~

ILLUSTRATIVE Engagement metrics, rewritten around the outcome. Screen prototyped for this course, numbers made up.



FOCUS IT · THE REAL RECORD

Your tree lives in the KPI Tracker

One row per driver, one column per module. Your agent fills it every Monday

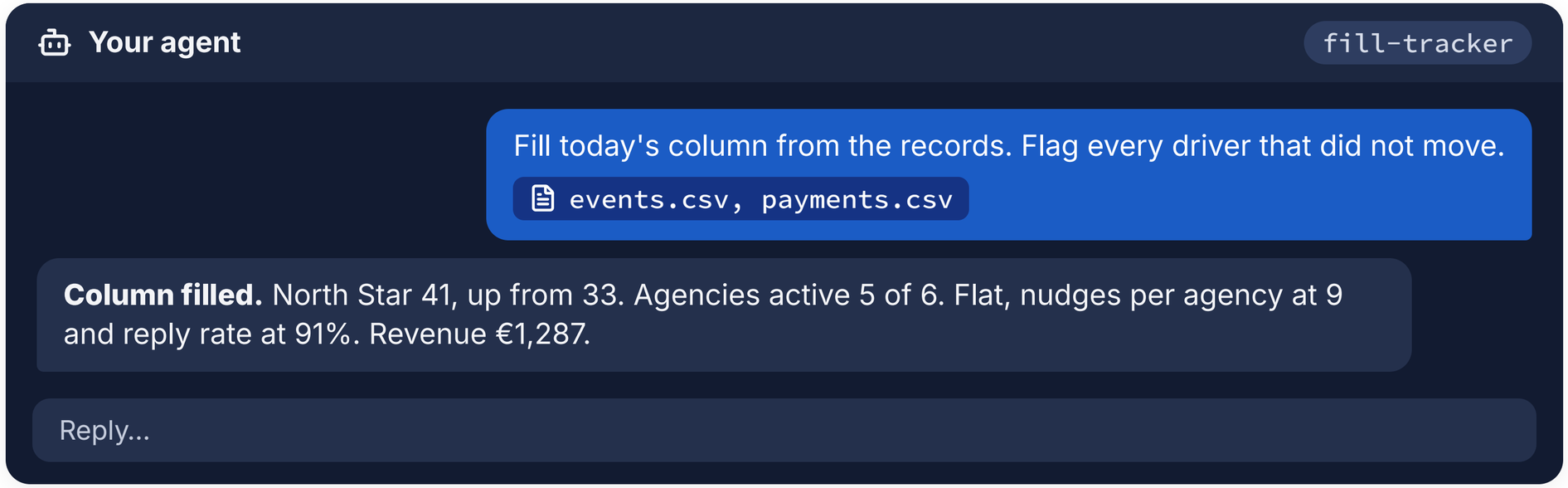
	A	B	C	D	E
1	**Metric**	**The kill decision (M07)**	**First users (M08)**	**Prototype to product (M09)**	**Product management (M10)**
2	North Star (your weekly count) · finalists nudged who replied		18	33	**41**
3	· New paying agencies				**1 in 7 days**
4	· Agencies active				**5 of 6**
5	· Nudges per agency				**9**
6	· Reply rate				**91%**
7	Paying Customers	1	4	5	**6**
8	Revenue (€)	49	594	1,089	**1,287**

Student Toolkit · KPI Tracker · drivers added under the North Star from today

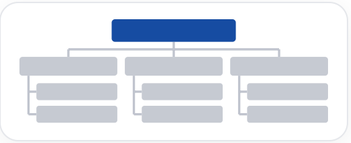
ILLUSTRATIVE Rows from the Student Toolkit KPI Tracker. Drivers from the KPI tree. Numbers and chat made up, the recruiter tool.

WITH YOUR AGENT · NOTHING BY HAND

Your tree lives in the KPI Tracker



ILLUSTRATIVE Rows from the Student Toolkit KPI Tracker. Drivers from the KPI tree. Numbers and chat made up, the recruiter tool.



KNOW YOUR NUMBERS! ARE YOU STICKY?

Growth shows whether your tree works

Bastian's rule of thumb for growth, month over month

Impressions

Clicks

Sign-ups

Users

Click-through rate

Sign-up rate

Active users

Growth / month

Must be > 10%
Should be > 20%
Outstanding at > 25%

NOW YOU · TEAMS · 3 MINUTES

Now you: name your North Star



Write what happens when a customer gets what they pay for

Count it per week

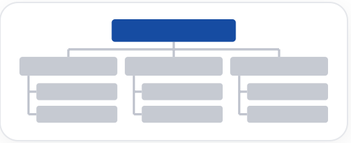
Name three drivers and an owner each

3:00

OUTPUT

A North Star and three owners

Photo: StartupStockPhotos on Pixabay.



INPUT 2 OF 4 · FOCUS IT · THE ANSWERS

Focus it: one North Star, an owner per driver

1

What is your North Star?

A count of what customers get, not what you get

2

How do you move it?

Through its drivers, new customers, retention and engagement, each with an owner

3

Where do you track it?

In the KPI Tracker, one row per driver, filled every Monday

INPUT 3 OF 4 · CHAPTER 5 OF 9

Choose it: build less, refuse more

Every yes costs more than it looks, so bet on what payers need and refuse kindly.

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03 ~~Count it: who stays and who leaves~~

04 ~~Focus it: one number and its drivers~~

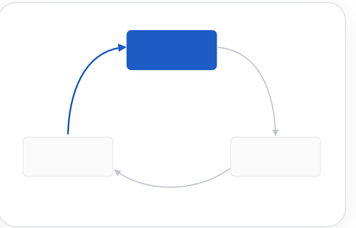
05 **Choose it: build less, refuse more**

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INPUT 3 OF 4 · CHOOSE IT · THREE QUESTIONS

What do you not build?

1

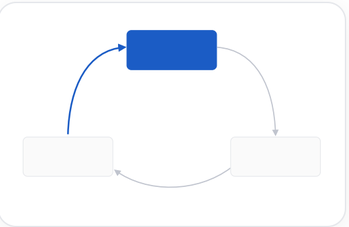
Why build less when building is cheap?

2

Which requests do you keep?

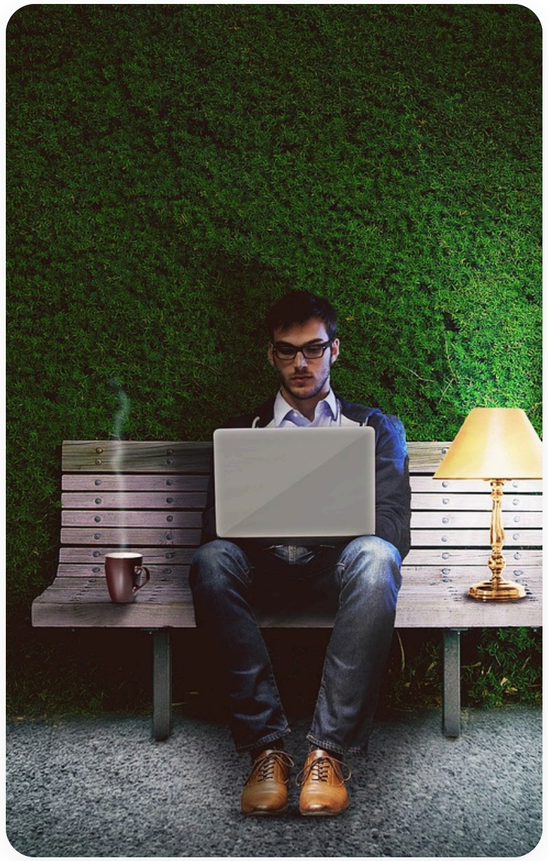
3

How do you say no?



MANAGING STARTUPS, THE SURE-FAIL WAY

Here's how to fail at managing a startup



From: your CEO · To: team — today

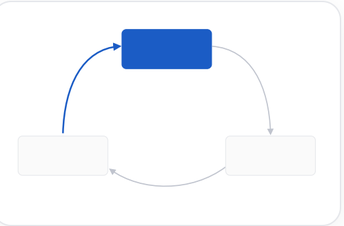
tl;dr: become AI-first asap;

Team, quick brain dump from your slightly sleep-deprived CEO: AI vibes are all over rn, impact tbd tbh but Q4 we need to raise and afaik investors just wanna see AI usage + graphs go up, so we're "aligning" on a NSM later lol;

pls crank out more 10x-ish features, slap "AI-powered" and agents on everything, and tighten GTM so sales/product/marketing aren't speedrunning in diff dirs while our PLG story still kinda works;

ship fast, dump stuff in Notion, put OKRs on top, dashboards trending up = lgtm, Slackbot already lgtm, react with 🚀/✅ and lmk eod if this works for you, xoxo.

Photo: 51581 on Pixabay.

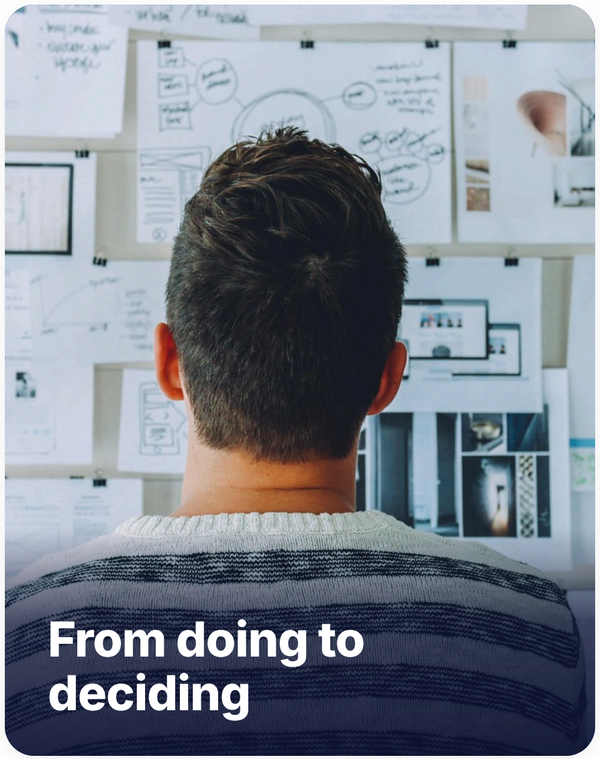


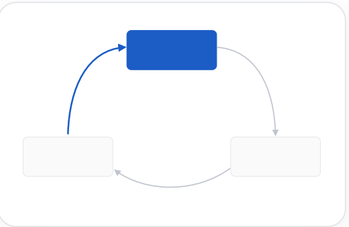
THE MINDSET SHIFT

Ask "should we build this?", not "can we?"

AI made building cheap. Deciding stayed expensive

EARLY STAGE		FROM NOW ON
"Can we build this?"	→	**"Should we build this?"**
"Say yes to every customer"	→	**"Serve the right customers deeply"**
"Features = progress"	→	**"Outcomes = progress"**
"Ship fast, fix later"	→	**"Ship right, iterate fast"**

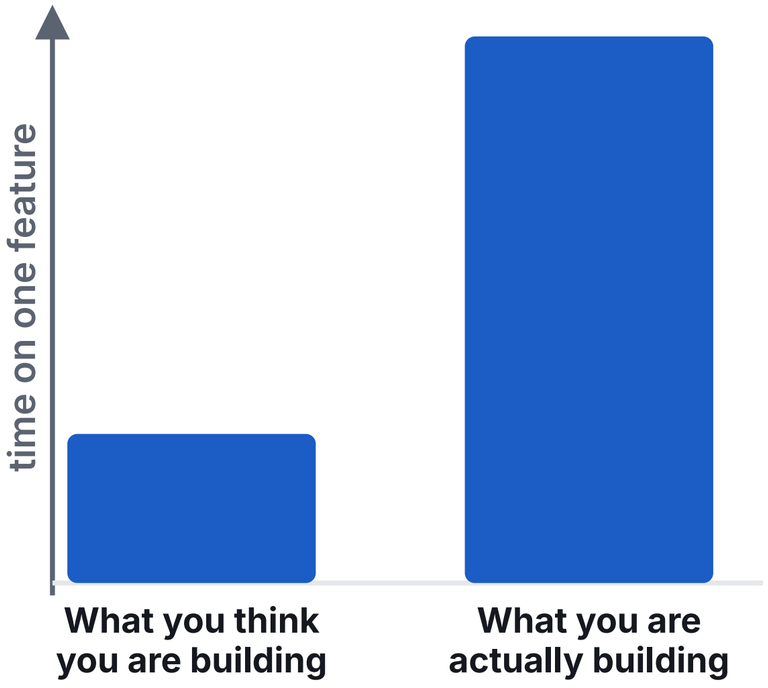


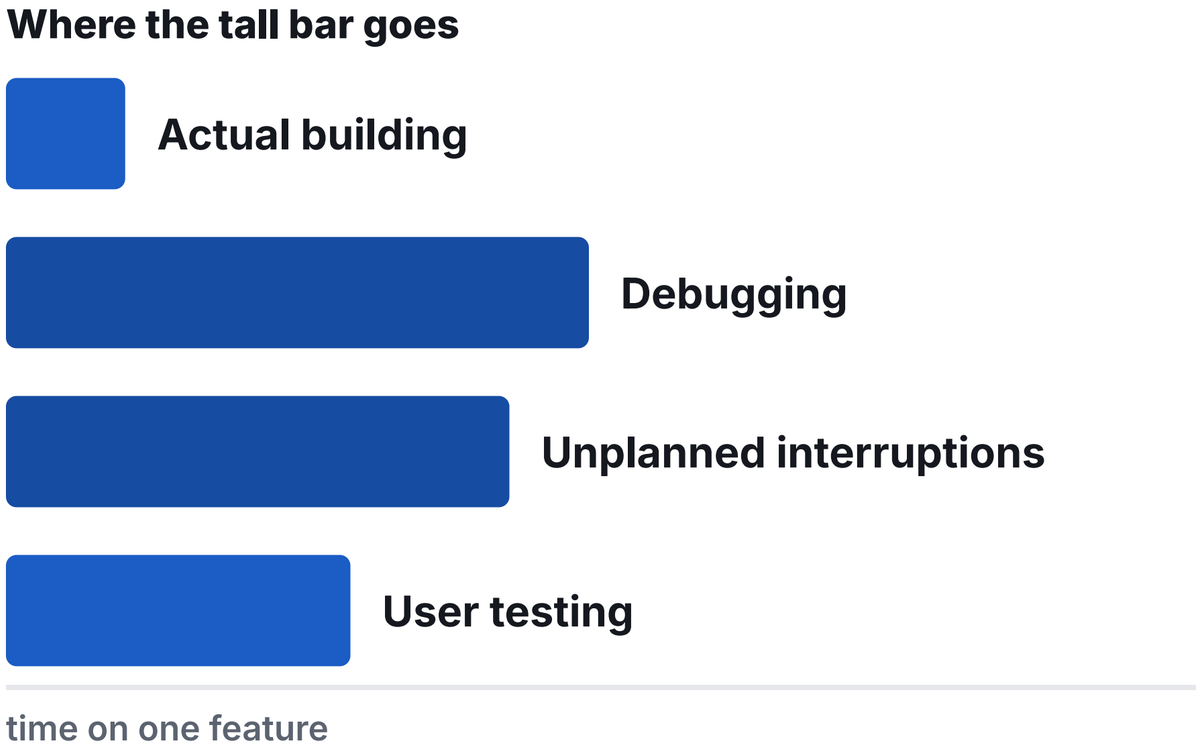


WHAT A YES COSTS

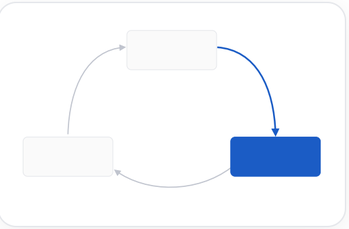
Every yes costs more than it looks

Building is the small bar. Debugging and interruptions are the big ones





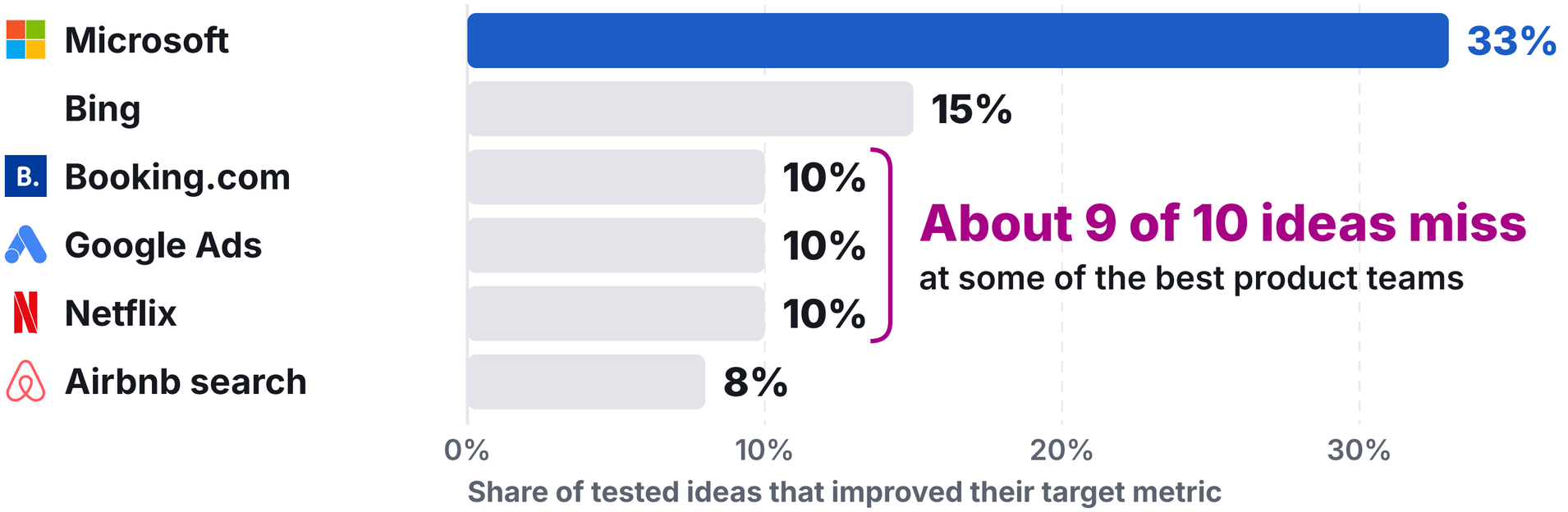
ILLUSTRATIVE Bar lengths are a picture of Bastian's experience, not measured data.



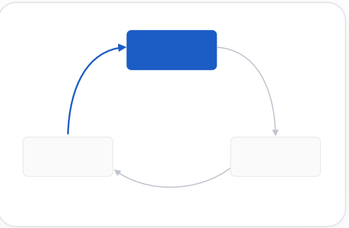
MOST IDEAS MISS

Most ideas don't move the number they aim at

Controlled A/B tests at large tech companies, ballpark figures



RESEARCH Kohavi, Deng & Vermeer (2022), KDD, table 2, "ballpark estimates". Kohavi et al. (2009), Microsoft. Logos are trademarks of their owners.



BETS

Write every request as a bet before you build it

116 Italian startups, randomized. Founders who tested did better

BET

Quiet-finalist alert in Slack

ASKED BY

Lena and 2 more agencies, all paying

DRIVER

Nudges per agency

EXPECTED EFFECT

From 9 to 12 a week by Founder health (M11)

WRITTEN ON

Tuesday, before the first line of code

RESULT

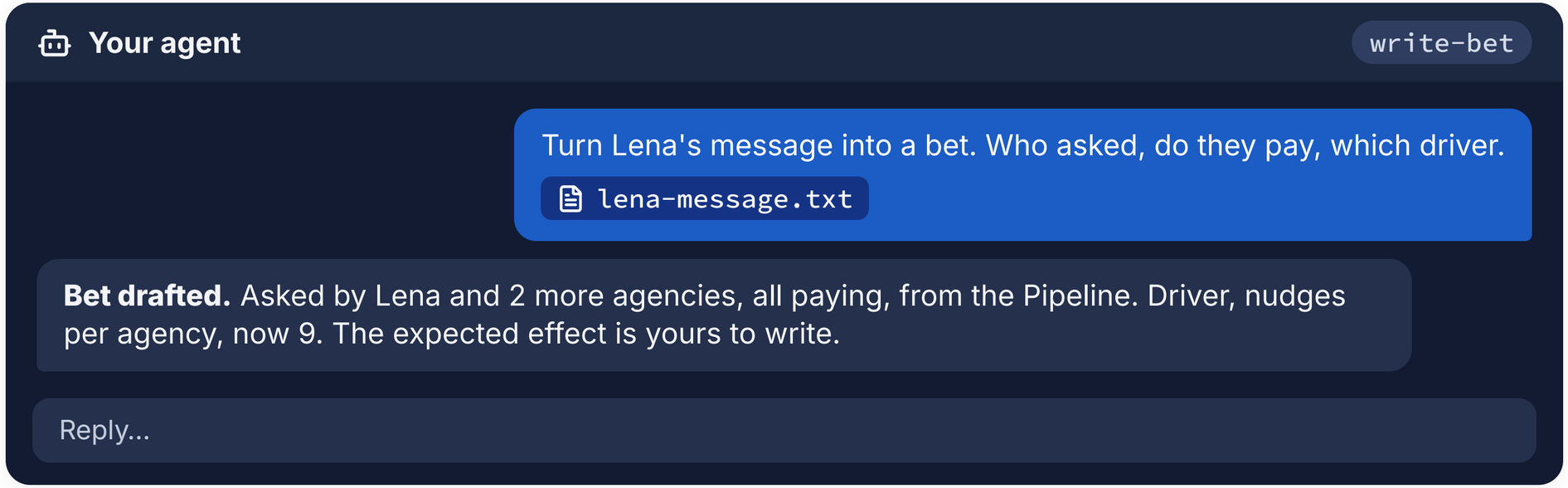
filled in after it ships

A bet names **who asked**, the **driver** it should move and the **effect** you expect, written before you build.

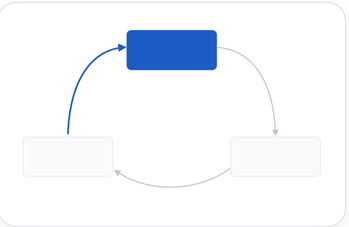
RESEARCH Camuffo, Cordova, Gambardella & Spina (2020), Management Science 66(2), randomized trial with 116 Italian startups. Camuffo et al. (2024), 759 firms. Bet card and chat made up.

WITH YOUR AGENT · NOTHING BY HAND

Write every request as a bet before you build it



RESEARCH Camuffo, Cordova, Gambardella & Spina (2020), Management Science 66(2), randomized trial with 116 Italian startups. Camuffo et al. (2024), 759 firms. Bet card and chat made up.



WHAT TO BUILD?

Every bet adds, removes or exchanges a feature

Build
experiments

Add a feature

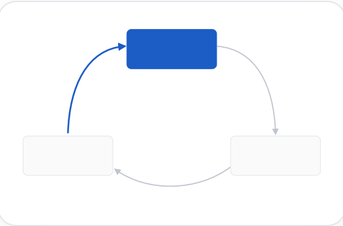
+ Build what customers want
+ Create the whole product
– Feature creep
– Harder to maintain

Remove a feature

+ Streamline the product
+ Easier to maintain
– Takes away from customers
– Might be the value

Exchange a feature

+ Build a better service
+ Reduce technical debt
– Old one was good enough
– Hard to measure



THE FILTER

Keep what payers need. Bury the rest

A paying customer asked and it deepens their outcome, or it fixes why someone left

14 requests, ideas and fixes

6 from paying customers

3 deepen the outcome or fix a loss

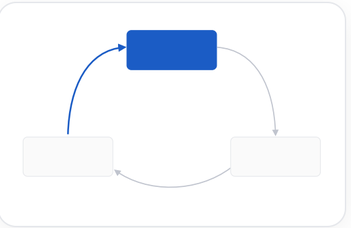
Number of requests, drawn to scale



Everything else goes to the graveyard

With a headstone that says why

ILLUSTRATIVE Counts made up, the recruiter tool. Photo: ClickerHappy on Pixabay.

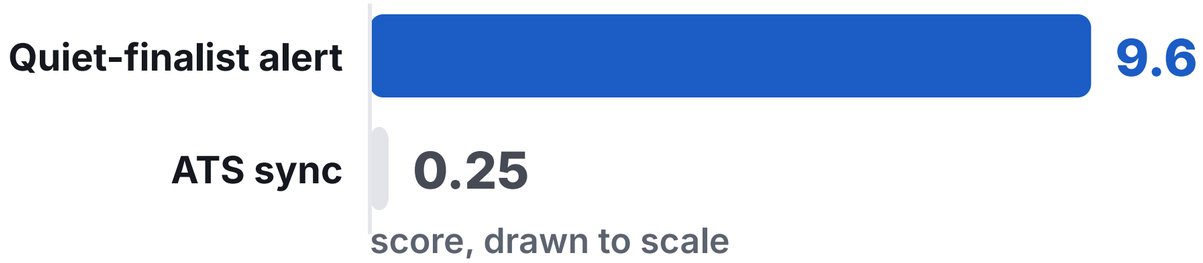


RICE

Rank the keepers by reach, impact, confidence and effort

Score = reach × impact × confidence ÷ effort, from Intercom

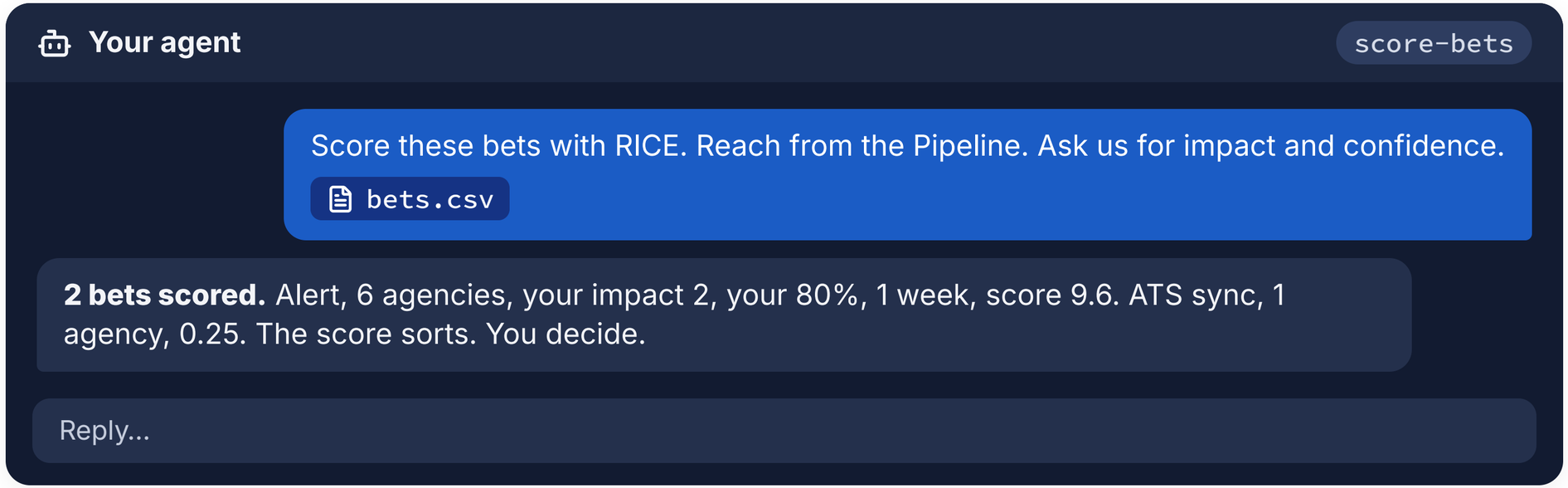
Bet	Reach	Impact	Confidence	Effort	Score
Quiet-finalist alert	**6 agencies**	**2**	**80%**	**1 week**	**9.6**
ATS sync	1 agency	2	50%	4 weeks	0.25

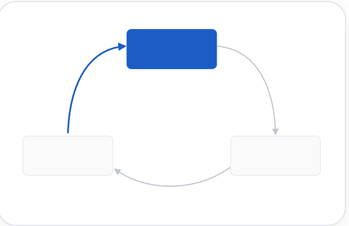


The score sorts the list. It does not decide for you. A bet that fixes why customers leave can jump the queue.

WITH YOUR AGENT · NOTHING BY HAND

Rank the keepers by reach, impact, confidence and effort





NOW YOU · ALONE · 3 MINUTES

Now you: write one bet



Pick your loudest request from a paying customer

Name the driver it moves and the effect you expect

Score it, reach times impact times confidence over effort

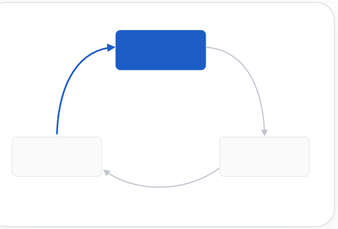
3:00

OUTPUT

One bet with an effect and a score

ROADMAP

Now, Next, Later. One Now bet per founder



your board tool · roadmap

Roadmap Board List No dates. Updated every Monday

Now 2 — Limit: 1 per founder

One bet per founder, its effect written

Quiet-finalist alert — Jonas

Driver	Nudges per agency
Expected	From 9 to 12 a week
Asked by	Lena and 2 more agencies, all paying

Monday digest — Mia

Driver	Agencies active
Expected	From 5 to 6 of 6

Ana: no build bet, she sells

Next 1

Roughly scoped, may change

Weekly report for hiring managers

Rough scope

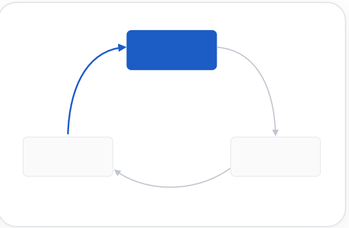
Later 1

Direction, no promise

ATS sync, if three payers ask

1 of 3 asked: Lena

ILLUSTRATIVE Now, Next, Later, popularised by ProdPad (Janna Bastow and Simon Cast, from 2012). "Only 1 per contributor" (Bastian). Screen and bets prototyped for this course.



SAYING NO

Say no kindly, even to a customer who pays

A no with a workaround keeps the customer. Silence loses them

New message

To L Lena · Agency 1 Tuesday

Subject ATS sync

Lena, no ATS sync this month. Export the CSV in two clicks, here's how.

If more agencies need it, we'll look again in December.

Send Draft saved

HOW TO SAY NO GRACEFULLY

> **"Not right now, but here's when..."**

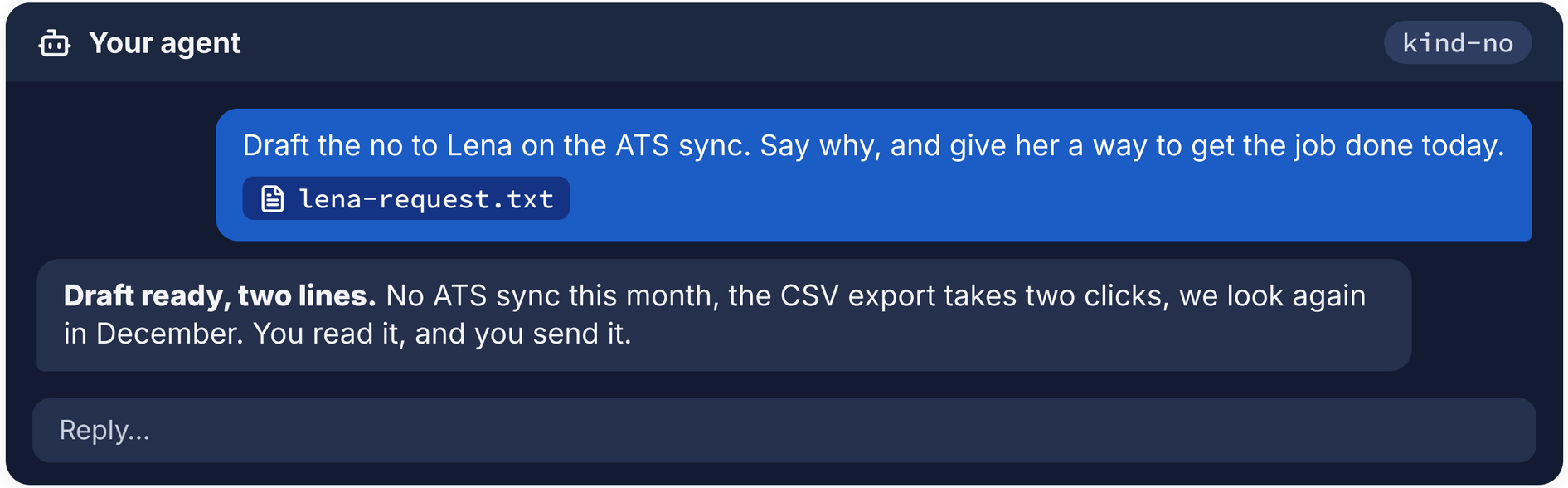
> **"Here's why we're prioritizing X instead"**

> **"Let me show you how to do Y instead"**

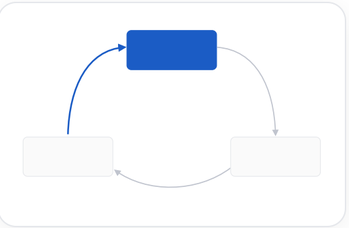
ILLUSTRATIVE Screen prototyped for this deck, message and chat made up, the recruiter tool. The rule of Prototype to product (M09), "say no to custom work, or price it apart".

WITH YOUR AGENT · NOTHING BY HAND

Say no kindly, even to a customer who pays



ILLUSTRATIVE Screen prototyped for this deck, message and chat made up, the recruiter tool. The rule of Prototype to product (M09), "say no to custom work, or price it apart".



CHOOSE IT · TIP

Tech debt is a bet too

Your agent-written code got you here fast. Decide when to pay it down

FROM

"First we clean up everything the agent wrote."

TO

Tech debt goes on the same list as every other bet.

your board tool · tech debt

Tech debt Same board as the bets

Fix now 3	Schedule it 3	Live with it 3
Export link opens without a login — Security holes	**Each new setting breaks the nudge form** — Code that slows you down	**The agent's report page is a mess** — Ugly but working code
Deleted nudges can't be restored — Data loss risks	**No test on sending a nudge** — Missing tests for core flows	**Rename the old tables** — "Nice to have" refactors
Some finalists get a nudge twice — Bugs customers hit	**Three manual steps to go live** — Deploy friction	**Dark mode, used by nobody** — Features nobody uses

ILLUSTRATIVE Screen prototyped for this course, items made up, the recruiter tool.

NOW YOU · ALONE · 4 MINUTES

Now you: bury one feature



Pick one request you won't build

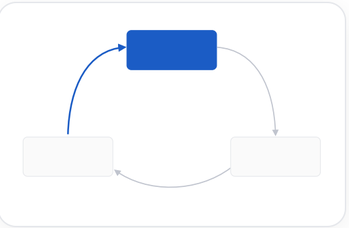
Write the two-line no to who asked

Send it today

4:00

OUTPUT

One no, ready to send



INPUT 3 OF 4 · CHOOSE IT · THE ANSWERS

Choose it: bets for payers, a kind no for the rest

1

Why build less when building is cheap?

Every yes costs more than it looks, and most ideas don't move the number

2

Which requests do you keep?

What payers need, written as bets and ranked by reach, impact, confidence and effort

3

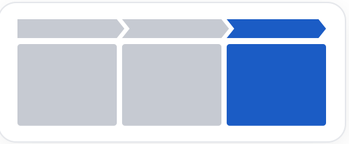
How do you say no?

Kindly, with a workaround, even to a customer who pays

Run it: the week, build or grow

Let the tree pick build or grow, ship small, and keep one founder selling.

01 ~~Previously on Ambitious Entrepreneurship~~
02 ~~Your presentations~~
03 ~~Count it: who stays and who leaves~~
04 ~~Focus it: one number and its drivers~~
05 ~~Choose it: build less, refuse more~~
06 **Run it: the week, build or grow**
07 Wrap-up and check-out
08 Workshop: Feature Graveyard
09 Case discussion



INPUT 4 OF 4 · RUN IT · THREE QUESTIONS

How do you run the week?

1

Build or grow?

2

How much process do you need?

3

How do you ship?

CORNERSTONE · THE THREE STAGES

Next stage, the growth phase. First step, build to validate

Problem space

Outcomes

Team committed for full-time work

Team completed by all necessary disciplines

Founders agree on hard and soft facts about funding

Agreement on an interesting problem space

Solution space

Outcomes

A fundable business with a clear business plan for the next 12 months

Paid pilot customers with completely conducted projects

Validated value proposition with real customers

Clear setup around team, processes, idea and more

Growth phase

Outcomes

Business gets progressively de-risked and starts turning profits

Fundable through Series A and B rounds

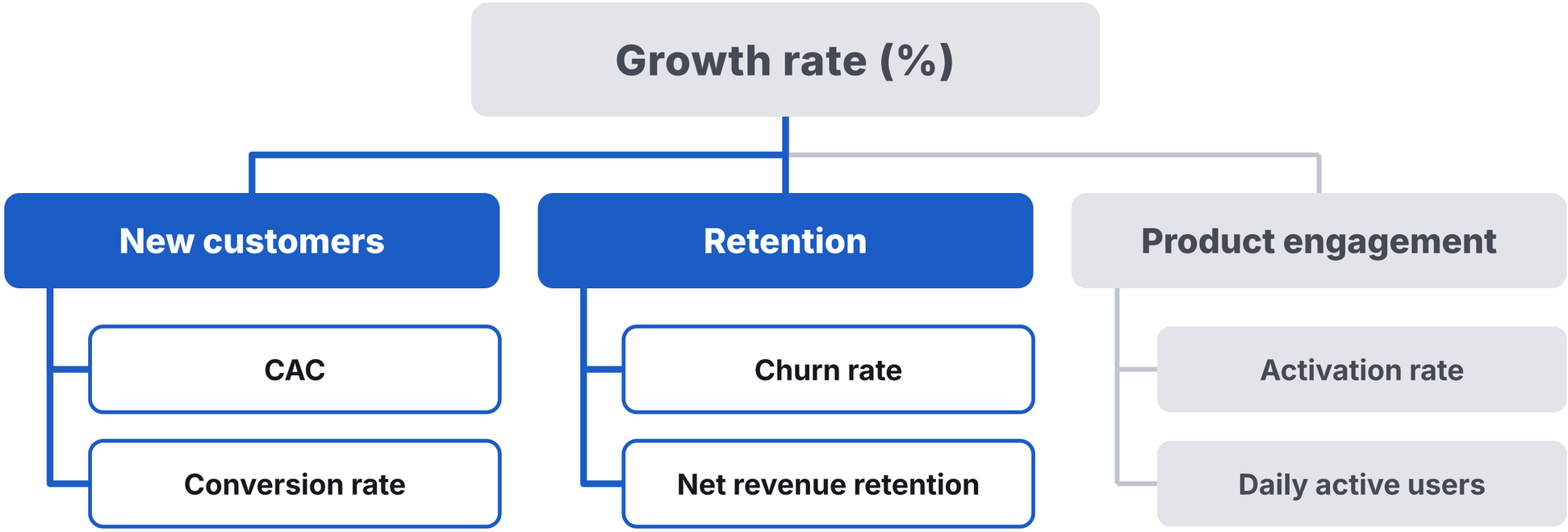
Self-sufficient business at each funding round

Gut feeling gets replaced by data in daily operations

BUILD OR GROW

Build or grow? Your tree decides





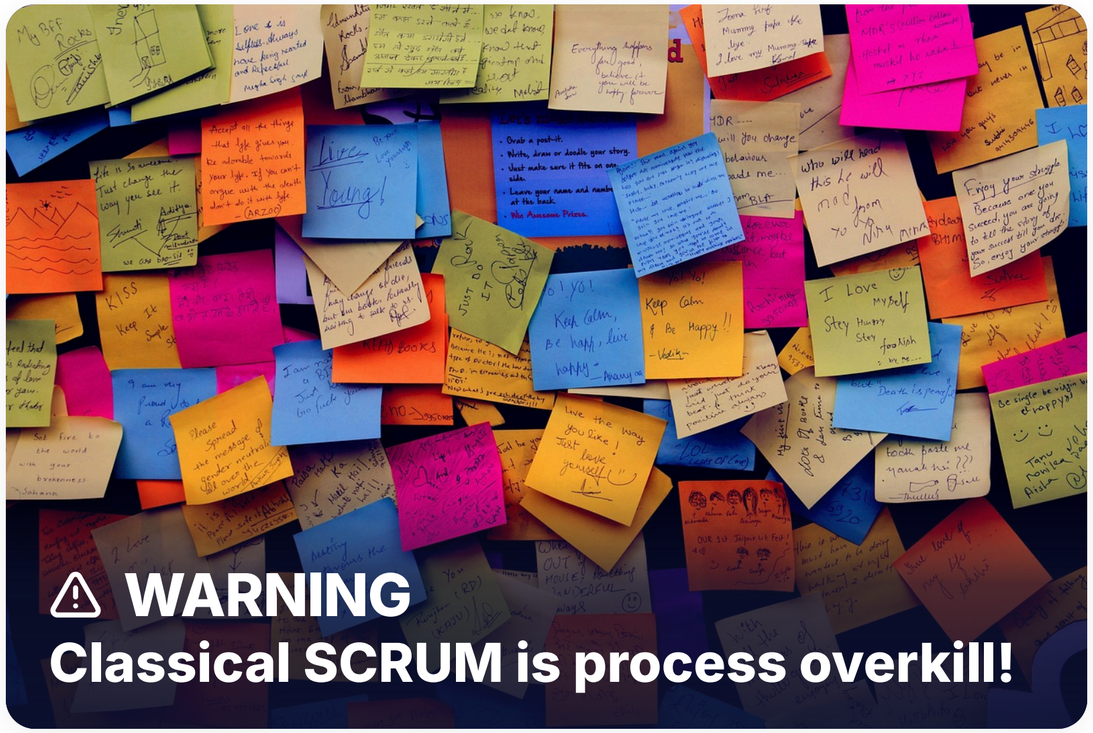
They find you but don't stay? → Build

They love it but can't find you? → Grow

Recruiter tool: 5 of 6 stay, 1 new a week → Grow

BASTIAN'S VIEW

Warning! Heavy process is overkill at five people





Photos: Pexels on Pixabay.

HEARTBEATS

Hang the plan on a heartbeat you can't move

Pick a date the world sets, so the plan can't slide

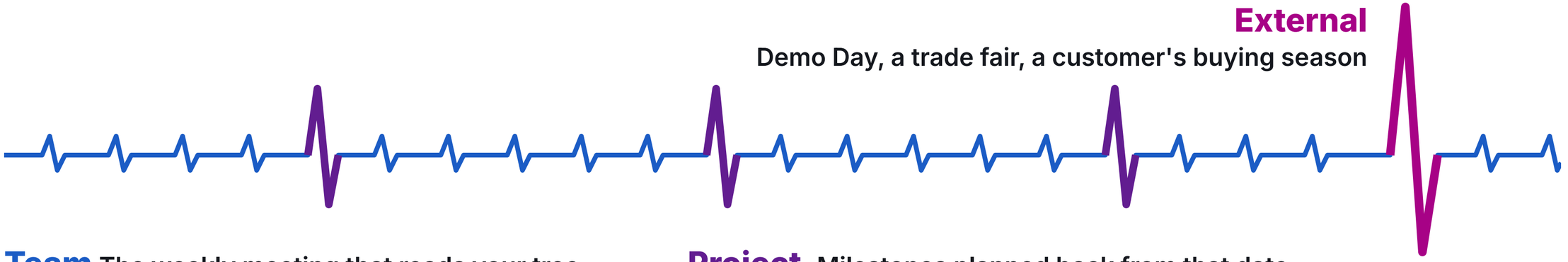
"The best external heartbeats aren't set by the company but by outside forces - like the holidays or a big conference."

Tony Fadell, *Build* (2022), chapter 3.5





External
Demo Day, a trade fair, a customer's buying season



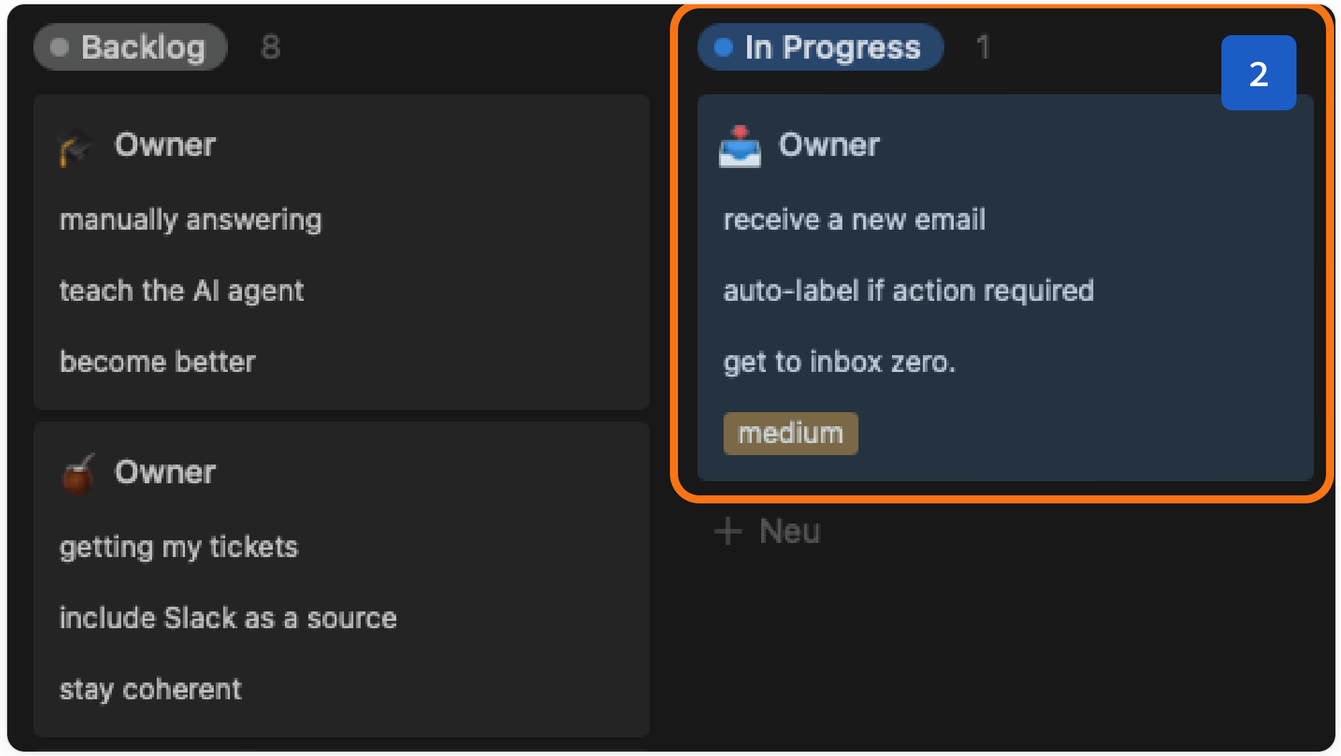
Team The weekly meeting that reads your tree

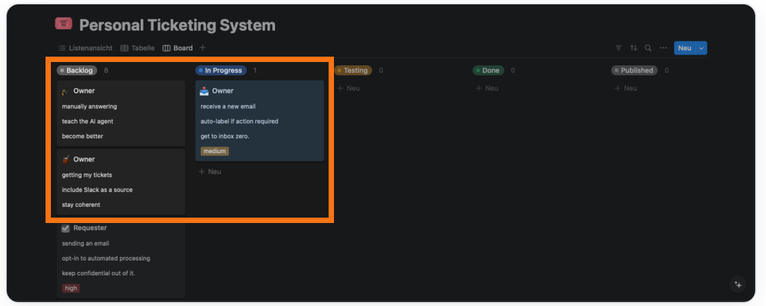
Project Milestones planned back from that date

FRAMEWORK Fadell, T. (2022). Build. Harper Business. The heartbeat line is a picture, not to scale. Photos: chriswanders, stux on Pixabay.

ONE BOARD · BASTIAN'S OWN

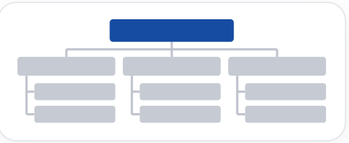
One board, one thing in progress per person





1. Backlog: don't touch during the week
2. **In progress: only 1 per person**
3. Testing: only by the feature's owner
4. Published: when live for customers

Screenshot from Bastian's course material, capture date not recorded. Any board tool works. Logos are trademarks of their owners.



THE WEEKLY MEETING

Read the tree together, once a week

One meeting, four items, every Monday. Your agent prepares it

team docs · meetings · Monday review

Monday review

Every Monday · 30 minutes · read, then decide

1 The tree

	before		now
North Star	33	→	**41**
Agencies active	4 of 5	→	**5 of 6**
Nudges per agency	9	→	**9**
Reply rate	91%	→	**91%**
New paying agencies	2	→	**1**

2 The past week's bets

M Setup checklist, new agencies — Hit

Expected: active 4 of 5 to 5 of 6. Now 5 of 6

J Nudge templates by role — Missed

Expected: reply rate 91% to 94%. Now 91%

3 The coming week

- J Quiet-finalist alert **nudges 9 to 12**
- M Monday digest **active 5 to 6 of 6**
- A No build bet, Ana sells

No to send: Lena, ATS sync — Drafted

4 Selling

Pipeline	Asks sent	Demos booked
8 agencies	**12**	**3**

Owner: Ana. Everyone brings one intro

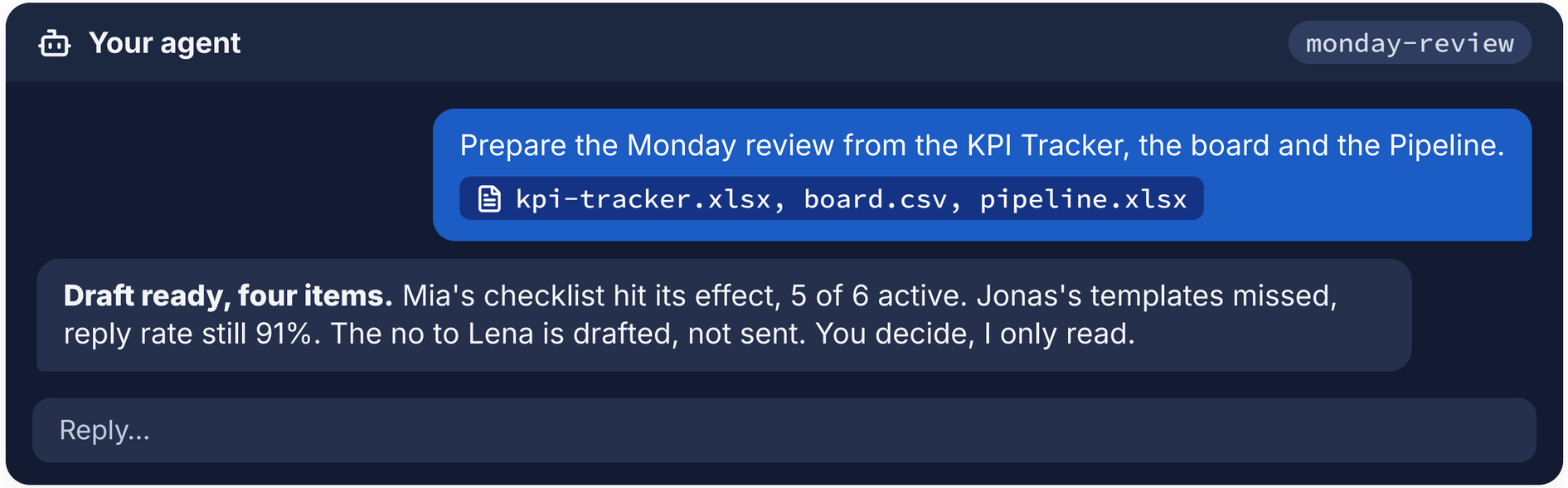
1. **The tree**
   North Star and drivers against the week before
2. **The past week's bets**
   Each against its expected effect
3. **The coming week**
   The Now list and the no's to send
4. **Selling**
   Who is on the pipeline, how many asks

"If you do it twice, **write it down.**"

ILLUSTRATIVE Doc and chat prototyped for this course, numbers made up. The weekly meeting, and "If you do it twice, write it down", after Mochary, The Great CEO Within ("When you do it twice, write it down").

WITH YOUR AGENT · NOTHING BY HAND

Read the tree together, once a week



ILLUSTRATIVE Doc and chat prototyped for this course, numbers made up. The weekly meeting, and "If you do it twice, write it down", after Mochary, The Great CEO Within ("When you do it twice, write it down").



PREVIOUSLY · THE KILL DECISION (M07)

In product work, this decision comes back every quarter

Go, Pivot or Kill. Per initiative, on a line written when it started

ONE QUARTER ON · MADE UP

Bet	Line	Read	Your call		
Quiet-finalist alert	At least 12 nudges per agency	**13**	**Go**	**Pivot**	**Kill**
Monday digest	6 of 6 agencies active	**5 of 6**	**Go**	**Pivot**	**Kill**
Weekly report for hiring managers	3 agencies open it	**1**	**Go**	**Pivot**	**Kill**

Every Monday you read each bet — **Every quarter you decide**

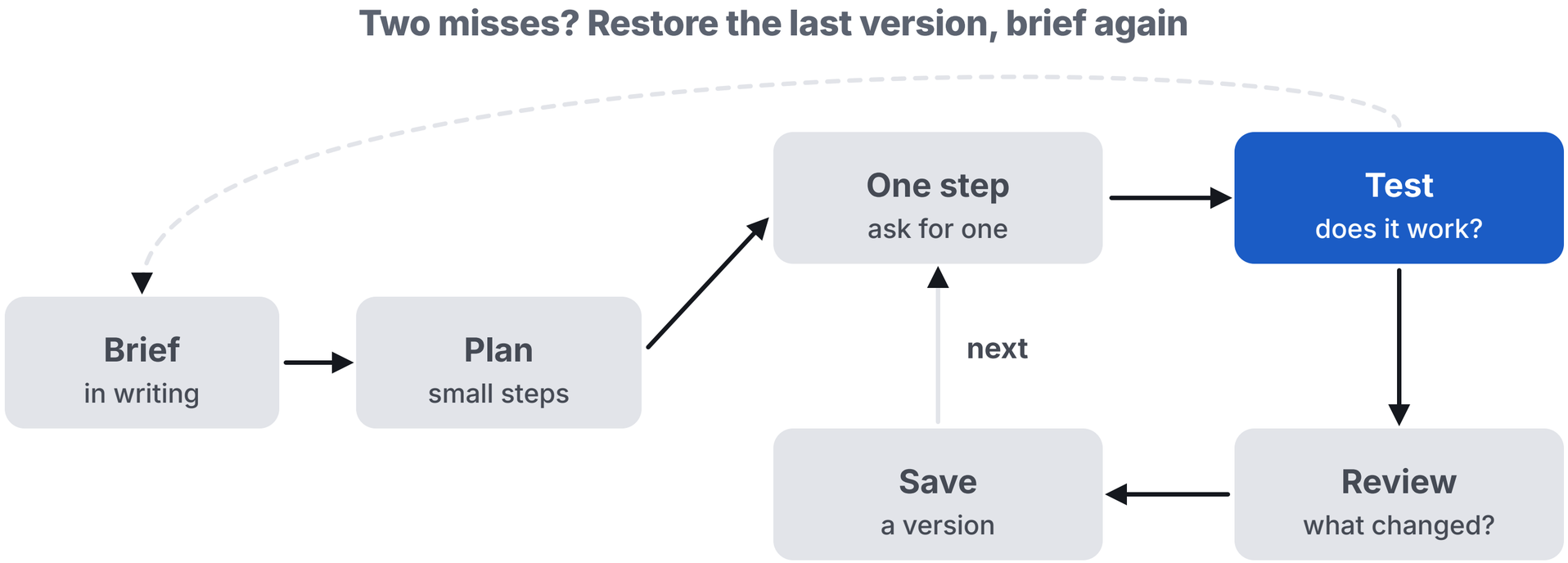
Each one is a bet with its expected effect, read every week

ILLUSTRATIVE Go, Pivot or Kill from The kill decision (M07). Bets, lines and results made up, the recruiter tool. Photo: RonaldCandonga on Pixabay.

SHIP SMALL

Ship each bet in small, tested steps

Expected effect first, then the brief, the step, the test, the save



THE STANDING RULE

Every single day, at least

1 founder sells



Building never pauses selling. Name the founder on the pipeline before you leave the room.

Photo: VinzentWeinbeer on Pixabay.

NOW YOU · TEAMS · 3 MINUTES

Now you: pick your mode



Choose **Build** **Grow** for the next stretch

Name the founder on the pipeline

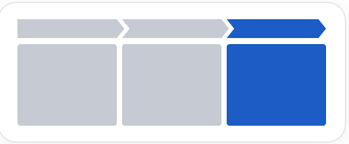
Name your next outside deadline

3:00

OUTPUT

A mode, a name, a date

Photo: StartupStockPhotos on Pixabay.



INPUT 4 OF 4 · RUN IT · THE ANSWERS

Run it: the tree picks, you ship small

1

Build or grow?

Your tree decides. Leaving means build, staying but few means grow

2

How much process do you need?

Little. One board, one thing in progress per person, one meeting on the tree, one verdict a quarter

3

How do you ship?

Each bet in small, tested steps, its expected effect first. One founder sells every day

CHAPTER 7 OF 9

Wrap-up and check-out

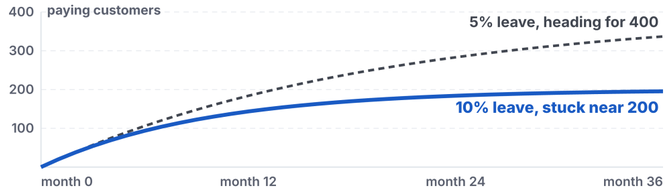
Three pictures to keep, three questions to reflect on, and your week.

01 ~~Previously on Ambitious Entrepreneurship~~
02 ~~Your presentations~~
03 ~~Count it: who stays and who leaves~~
04 ~~Focus it: one number and its drivers~~
05 ~~Choose it: build less, refuse more~~
06 ~~Run it: the week, build or grow~~
07 **Wrap-up and check-out**
08 Workshop: Feature Graveyard
09 Case discussion

RECAP · TODAY

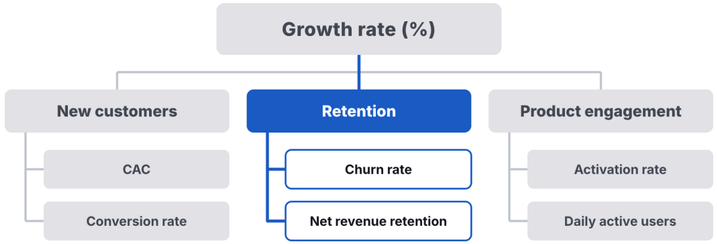
Who stays, one number, build or grow

WHO STAYS



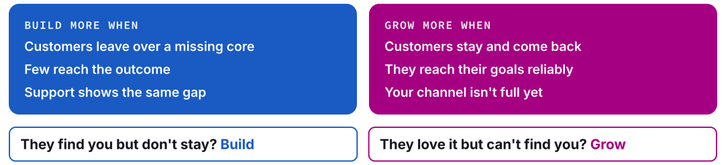
Leavers cap your growth. Count who came back

ONE NUMBER



One number for the value customers get, an owner per driver

BUILD OR GROW



They leave? Build. They stay but can't find you? Grow

What do you build next? Only what makes paying customers stay. Everything else goes to the graveyard, with a kind note

REFLECTION 1 OF 3 · THE CONTENT

What could you apply?



What could you apply?



What gave you a hard time?

REFLECTION 2 OF 3 · THE PROCESS

Man vs. machine



Where did AI actually help you?



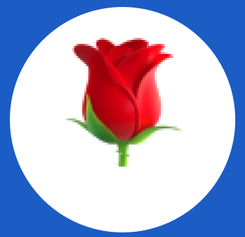
Where was your genius needed?



What are your best hacks to share?

REFLECTION 3 OF 3 · THE RESULTS

Rose, thorn, bud



What was the breakthrough today?



What was the hardest part today?



What is an idea/feature you didn't have time to finish, but want to explore later?

HOMEWORK UNTIL NEXT TIME

Reach €3,000 cumulative revenue from outside your social graph, shown in your payment dashboard or on paid numbered invoices.

€3,000 full bar

The learning floor is €1,000 cumulative.

Your kill line sits in the Kill Criteria Log, dated, before you open your records. No line? "If fewer than half of our paying customers who paid 14 or more days ago used the outcome or paid again by [the day before Module 11], we build no new feature next week and fix the core with the ones who left." Log it before you open your records. Answers to the question never count.

HOMEWORK · HOW TO DO IT

Count who came back, say no in writing, ship small, sell daily

1. **Skipped the workshop?** Run its three steps as a team first (Feature Graveyard).
2. **Read your records, not your inbox.** Each paying customer once.
3. **Call those who left** within two days. Ask what happened last time.
4. **Read the question's answers** next to who came back. The "very disappointed" who returned would miss you most.

! **Watch out.** Under 20, write counts.

5. **Ship Now bets in small, tested steps,** effect written first. Missed? No sequel.
6. **Say no in writing** to every customer whose request you buried.
7. **Keep one founder selling daily,** your Pipeline's "later" answers first.
8. **Read your tree together weekly.** Write down any chore done twice.
9. **Get a blind second opinion.** Give an AI your raw records, no names or hypothesis. Note where it disagrees.

HOMEWORK · WHAT YOU COME BACK WITH

Good is counted, bet on and read weekly

	GOOD	WEAK
STAYING	5 of 7 back, 2 lost, reasons in their words	"Retention 71%"
BUILDING	2 bets shipped, 1 hit its effect	6 features nobody asked for
RHYTHM	41 nudges replied, read every Monday	A dashboard nobody opens

Sources in this deck

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Bury it, ship it, sell it. See you in Founder health (M11)!

MODULE 10 · PRODUCT MANAGEMENT & GROWTH · WORKSHOP · 90 MINUTES

Workshop: Feature Graveyard

Count who stayed, pick one number, bury the rest.

01 Previously on Ambitious Entrepreneurship

02 Your presentations

03 **Count it: who stays and who leaves**

04 **Focus it: one number and its drivers**

05 **Choose it: build less, refuse more**

06 **Run it: the week, build or grow**

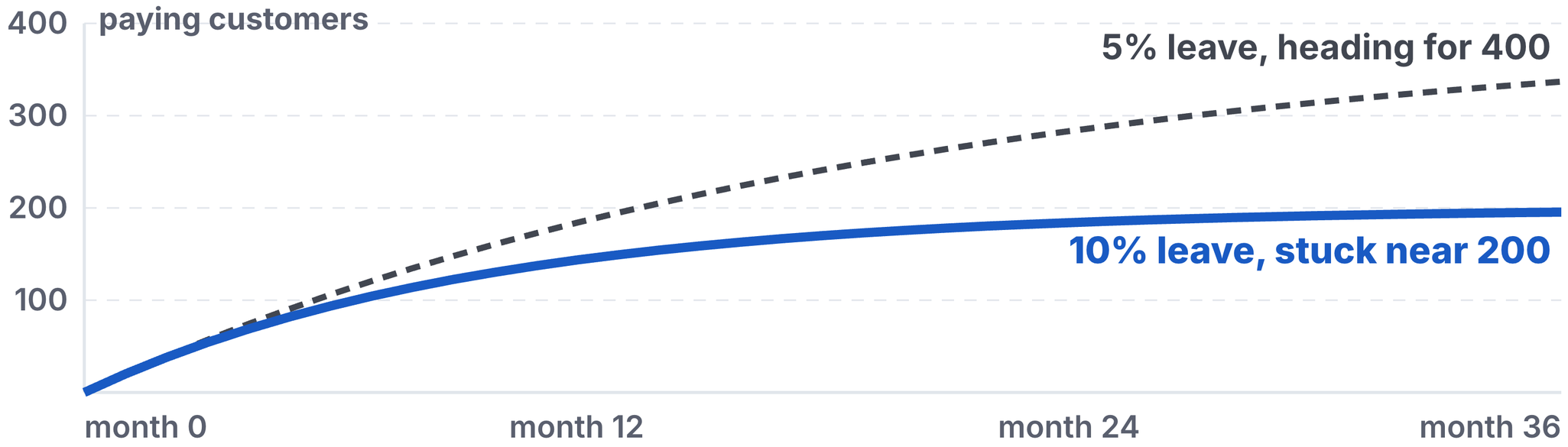
07 Wrap-up and check-out

08 **Workshop: Feature Graveyard**

09 Case discussion

WORKSHOP · THE FIGURE FOR STEP 1

Leavers cap your growth



WORKSHOP · THE FIGURE FOR STEP 2

One number, a few drivers, an owner each



HOMEWORK UNTIL NEXT TIME

Reach €3,000 cumulative revenue from outside your social graph, shown in your payment dashboard or on paid numbered invoices.

€3,000 full bar

The learning floor is €1,000 cumulative.

Your kill line sits in the Kill Criteria Log, dated, before you open your records. No line? "If fewer than half of our paying customers who paid 14 or more days ago used the outcome or paid again by [the day before Module 11], we build no new feature next week and fix the core with the ones who left." Log it before you open your records. Answers to the question never count.

WORKSHOP · STEP 1 OF 3

Count who stayed

1 STEP 1 · 25 MIN

COUNT WHO STAYED

Who came back, from your product's records.

- → Log your line before you open your records
- → List every paying customer and first payment date
- → Mark who came back, with dates, counts under 20
- → Ask core users: very, somewhat, not disappointed?

Output A line, customers marked, question sent.

Minutes 25



25:00

ARRIVED EMPTY-HANDED?

No paying customers yet? Count your activated users



No paying customers yet? Use your activated users from the Use Log. No product records? Mark from your payment dashboard and add the outcome row this week.

WORKSHOP · STEP 2 OF 3

One number, every bet

2 STEP 2 · 30 MIN

ONE NUMBER, EVERY BET

One number, and every idea as a bet.

- → Pick a North Star, weekly value paying customers get
- → Break it into 3 to 5 drivers with owners
- → Write every request, idea and fix as a bet
- → Keep what deepens a payer's outcome or fixes a loss
- → Rank the keepers by impact and effort, or RICE

Output North Star, tree, every request a bet.

Minutes 30



30:00

WORKSHOP · STEP 3 OF 3

Bury, choose, commit

3 STEP 3 · 35 MIN

BURY, CHOOSE, COMMIT

Say no, pick the stretch, commit.

- → Bury the rest, one line on why
- → Write the no to each payer who asked, send one
- → They stay but few find you? Grow. They leave? Build
- → Now, Next, Later against a date you can't move
- → Commit to the bar, targets, midweek pace

Output No's sent, build or grow, Now list, targets.

Minutes 35



35:00

Bury it, ship it, sell it. See you in Founder health (M11)!

MODULE 10 · PRODUCT MANAGEMENT & GROWTH · CASE DISCUSSION · ABOUT 90 MINUTES

Case discussion: Tally

Sit with Marie Martens and Filip Minev in late July or early August 2021 and decide what a two-founder form builder builds next.

01 Previously on Ambitious Entrepreneurship
02 Your presentations
03 **Count it: who stays and who leaves**
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07 Wrap-up and check-out
08 Workshop: Feature Graveyard
09 **Case discussion**

CASE · TALLY, BELGIUM, LATE JULY OR EARLY AUGUST 2021 · VOTE 1 OF 2

What should Minev build next for Tally?

Integrations
Option 1

Customization
Option 2

Analytics
Option 3

Onboarding
Option 4

Something else
Option 5

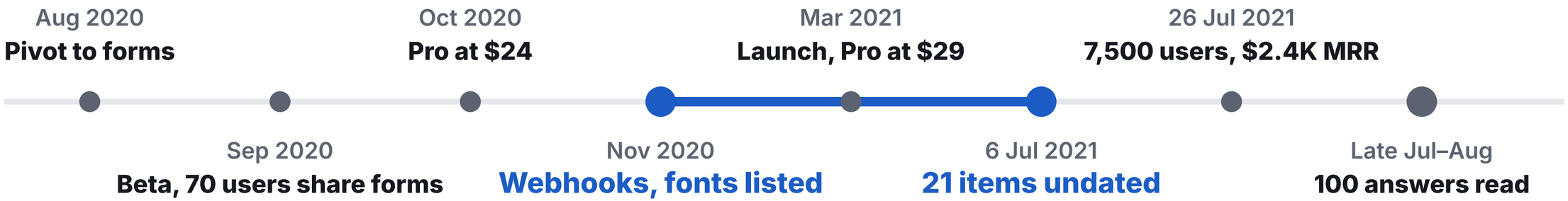
No new feature, grow
Option 6

DATA Product management (M10) case: Tally. The request groups as Martens summarised them, plus growing instead of building.

CASE · WHAT HAPPENED UNTIL LATE JULY 2021

One year, one builder, and a roadmap that kept growing

Nothing after the case moment



DATA Product management (M10) case: Tally, the case text, Exhibits 1 and 3. Nothing after late July or early August 2021.

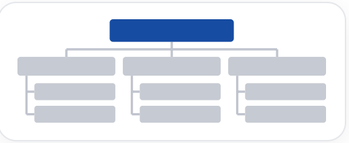
CASE · EXHIBIT 2 · 30 MINUTES

66 of 115 would be very disappointed. Do they stay?

Answers when the results were published on 5 August 2021



DATA Product management (M10) case: Tally, Exhibit 2, after Martens, "How to measure your Product-Market Fit", Tally blog, 5 August 2021. The 40% line is the course's own calculation, 0.4 × 115 = 46.



CASE · EXHIBIT 1 · WHICH NUMBER?

Which of these numbers tells you whether users stay?

The founders' own figures, dated

Late 2020

What they watched

- People who tried it
- Forms made
- Forms shared, responses received
- Revenue, 1 to 2% expected to pay

26 July 2021

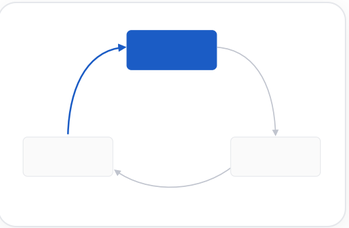
What they reported

- 7,500 users
- $2.4K MRR, the "primary metric"
- "7% weekly and 15% monthly (MRR)"
- "about 3% conversion"

5 August 2021 · 10 days later

What they published

- 8,000 users
- 100 Tally Pro users
- $2.4K MRR
- "User" never defined



CASE · EXHIBIT 3 · 20 MINUTES

Seven requests. Which one next?

Request group	Users asked for	On the roadmap, 6 July 2021	Since	Pro, Nov 2020
Analytics and reporting	Visual results, open and response rates	Analytics 4th of 21	By Apr 2021	No
Customization	Colours, fonts, themes, columns	Columns 10th, fonts and colours 16th, 3 more 17th to 19th	Nov 2020	No
Integrations	Sheets, Notion, webhooks, API	Webhooks 1st, API access 2nd	Nov 2020	No
Payment options	PayPal	PayPal 13th, subscriptions 3rd	Nov 2020	Subscriptions*
Onboarding	Templates, examples of use	No item. Gallery live since Nov 2020	Not listed	No
UX improvements	Grouping blocks, Undo	Undo planned 5 to 11 Jul, not shipped	By Jun 2021	No
Embed options	Video, a form over the page	Video 15th, pop-up form 12th*	Nov 2020	Pop-up form

DATA Product management (M10) case: Tally, Exhibit 3, Tally's roadmap as archived. Positions among 21 undated items. * The case writer's match.

CASE · THE BOARD PLAN

One row per request, the same five questions

Votes · first count · second count

Request group	Who asked (what the case says)	Do they pay?	Number it should move	Cost for one builder	Keep or refuse
Integrations					Keep Refuse
Customization					Keep Refuse
Analytics					Keep Refuse
Onboarding					Keep Refuse
Payments, UX, embeds					Keep Refuse

Numbers that don't add up



CASE · BUILD OR GROW · 10 MINUTES

Should the next weeks go to building at all?

A free plan that, in Martens's words, needs "a lot more users to grow"

Their time



About half each. Both wanted more for marketing and content

Their plan for growth

Communities, the badge, then "user-generated content and SEO"

The badge



About one new user in ten

The summer

"growth started slowing down, which made us nervous", Martens wrote in October 2021

CASE · VOTE 2 OF 2

Same question. Who moved, and why?

Integrations

Option 1

Customization

Option 2

Analytics

Option 3

Onboarding

Option 4

Something else

Option 5

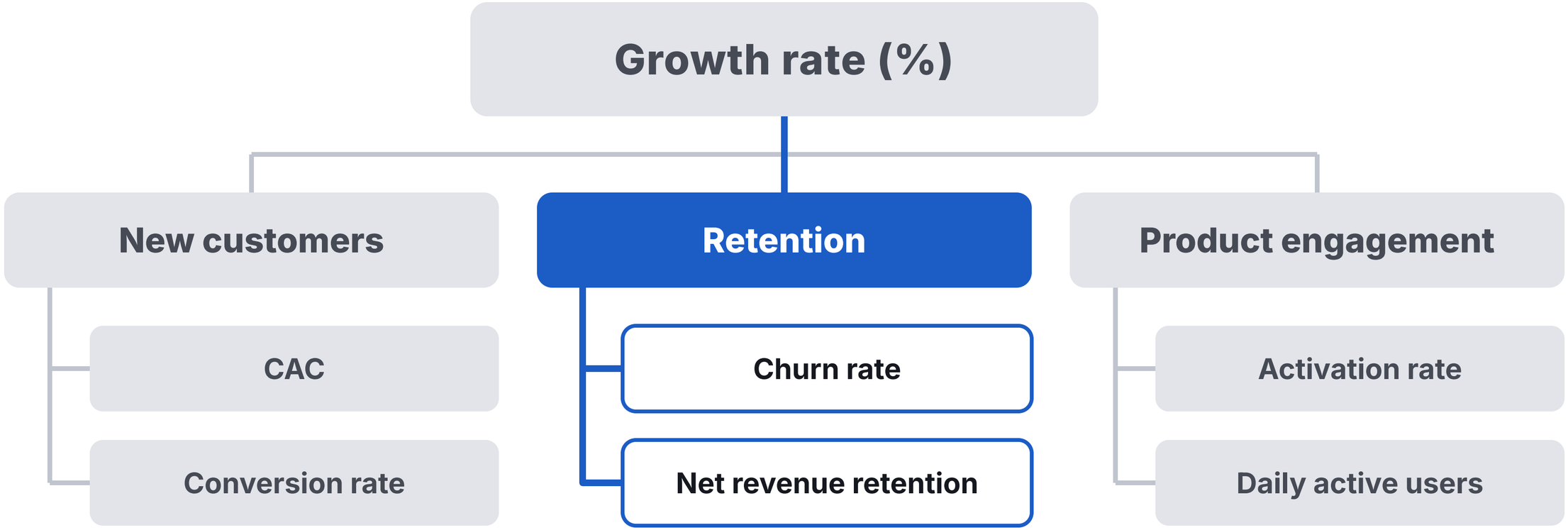
No new feature, grow

Option 6

DATA Product management (M10) case: Tally. The request groups as Martens summarised them, plus growing instead of building.

CASE · BRIDGE · YOUR STEP 1

Count who stayed before you read your survey



See you next time!